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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Visitors taking boat ride in Fewa Lake, Pokhara.

PM stresses support to women entrepreneurs

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 2



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has asked the Ministry of Women, Children and Senior Citizens to prioritise women entrepreneurs.

Meeting with Minister for Women, Children and Senior Citizens Surendra Raj Aacharya, the ministry's secretary and other officials on Tuesday, Prime Minister Prachanda stressed that women rights could be achieved only if women were financially self-sufficient and instructed the ministry to implement a policy of prioritising industries and businesses run by women.

The Prime Minister called it paramount to acknowledge the role played by Nepali women in bringing about political changes in the country and highlighted the need to take account of their political, economic and social conditions.

He further directed the ministry to conduct necessary research and formulate an action plan to realise the rights guaranteed by the constitution. For this, he asked it to prepare a list of policy, structural and programmatic actions to be included in next fiscal year's policy and programmes and budget.

He presented a 14-point directive to the ministry to strengthen its capacity to work for the welfare of women, children and senior citizens from all economic, ethnic and social backgrounds.

"The Ministry of Women, Children and Senior Citizens is a very sensitive ministry. But we have not been able to pay as much attention to it as we should. We need to restructure the ministry now," he said.

Meanwhile, Minister Aacharya told the Prime Minister that there had been some problems at juvenile correction homes in recent times, but claimed that they were due to existing legal provisions. He emphasised the need to take steps to remedy them.

The same day, Prime Minister Prachanda also spoke at an education summit in the capital and expressed concern at even people with lucrative jobs choosing to leave everything to move abroad.

"There are people who are forced to leave the country because of a lack of employment and other opportunities. But then there are those who, despite having good jobs and much social prestige, leave," he observed. "The desire to earn a lot very fast is driving many out of the country. This is worrisome."

Prachanda further called for the transformation of the nation's education policy, curriculum and transformation.

He noted that globalisation had created several challenges for small nations like Nepal and advocated for the development of an education system that can overcome those challenges.

The Prime Minister also reminded all that the younger generation felt the nation's education lacked quality and was not competitive in the global market. "This perception is being expressed in the form of out-migration," he told everyone gathered.

PRESIDENT STRESSES ENGAGEMENT OF STUDENTS IN SPORTS

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 2

President Ramchandra Paudel has said classrooms are the places for awakening students and sports is a tool for keeping them physically and mentally active as well as disciplined.

In his address to an inaugural session of the third President Running Shield Tournament organised by the Kathmandu Metropolitan City here on Tuesday, the Head of the State said extra-curricular activities including sports make the education system broader, opening avenues for self-confidence, positivity and talents-valued social life among students. Describing education and sports as two sides of a coin, the President said sports encourages students to become self-dependent and empowered.

He also drew the attention of authorities concerned for undertaking sufficient efforts for the development and promotion of sports in each level: federal, province and local. Citing that only books and classroom-based learning is not sufficient to make the student complete, he said sports is instrumental for broadening their learning horizon. It helps them explore new ideas and innovations, according to him.

Also speaking on the occasion, Kathmandu Metropolis mayor Balendra Shah said sports is the means of empowering students physically and mentally, and it should be promoted within from the school. Deputy mayor Sunita Dangol underlined the need of promoting sports to produce human resources capable to contribute to nation building.

A total of 3,250 students from 83 schools are competing for various tittles in six games: volleyball, Kabbadi, taekwondo, athletics, karate and wushu in the three-day tournament.

Nepal's Urban population reaches 27.07 %

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 2

The data shows imbalance in distribution of the urban population with highest concentration in the Tarai - in Madhes and Lumbini.

Contrary to the earlier projections, the National Statistics Office (NSO) said that Nepal's urban population has significantly increased from 22.31 per cent to 27.07 per cent between 2011 and 2021.

According to a report on Degree of Urbanisation in Nepal published by the NSO on Tuesday, peri-urban population has increased from 39.19 per cent to 39.75 per cent. Further, the rural population has decreased from 38.5 per cent to 33.19 per cent in the last 10 years.

In the rural municipalities, 58 per cent of the population is in the rural cluster within 2,412 wards, while 36.1 per cent is mostly in peri-urban areas (664 wards) and 5.9 per cent of the population is in the urban areas (139 wards).

According to the report, even in the municipalities, only 28.4 per cent of the population is in the urban areas (591 wards), 46 per cent is in the peri-urban areas (1,285 wards) and 25.4 per cent is in the rural cluster within 1,244 wards.

These results are contrary to the projections of urban population made so far in the country. According to the Census data of 2021, the urban municipality population is 66.17 per cent and that of the rural municipality is 33.83 per cent.

Since the population in 66.27 per cent urban areas is not further categorised into urbanising or peri-urban municipalities, it was necessary to study and contextualise the international practices to re-define the level of urbanisation of the municipal population, said Dr. Hemraj Regmi, Spokesperson for the NSO.

Majority of the population still resides in peri-urban areas that are regarded as 'urban', while in character are urbanising. Yet, the rural population is still one third, while based on the trend, the migration from rural areas to peri and urban areas provides an insight of pressure on the urban areas to accommodate and for the rural areas to retain the population, said Dr. Regmi.

The NSO has made the rural, peri-urban and urban classification at the ward level, based on the threshold of population, population density, rasterised built-up area and contiguity of the characteristics.

Further, in terms of the ecological region, the rural population is concentrated in the Hill (66 per cent) and Mountain regions (16 per cent). Peri-urban population is concentrated in the Tarai region (85 per cent) and urban population is concentrated in the Hill region (53 per cent), which is skewed due to Pokhara Metropolitan City and Kathmandu valley, followed by the Tarai region (39 per cent).

Similarly, in sub-metropolitan cities, 39 per cent of the population is in peri-urban areas and 53 per cent is living in urban categorised areas. In metropolitan cities, 17 per cent is in peri-urban areas, 2.3 per cent is in areas of rural characteristics and 80.7 per cent in urban areas.

Even in urban municipalities, the main characteristic of the settlement is still peri-urban and a significant population in the rural landscape, concluded the NSO. Likewise, the total number of wards in rural municipalities are higher (3,685) when compared to the urban and peri-urban areas, noting it contains only 33 per cent of the total population.

In terms of province-based calculation, the highest population concentration is in Madhes Province (19.9 per cent), followed by Bagmati Province (14.6 per cent) and the lowest in Karnali Province (1.2 per cent).

The data shows imbalance in distribution of the urban population with highest concentration in the Tarai - in Madhes and Lumbini. In Madhes Province, the majority of the wards (971) are of peri-urban characteristics. Bagmati is the second most urban province, where there are 672 rural wards in comparison to 449 wards in peri and urban areas. In Karnali Province, 637 wards are of rural characteristics with 75 wards of urban and six of peri urban characteristics.

Currently, Nepal has three-tiered government system. It comprises 753 local units or municipalities. Among them, 293 are urban municipalities (including metropolitan and sub-metropolitan cities) and 460 are rural municipalities.

The NSO had used the methodology of the United Nations Statistical Commission to harmonise the definition of urban and rural areas globally.

Indian Minister S. Jaishankar arriving tomorrow

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 2



External Affairs Minister of India S. Jaishankar is visiting Nepal for two days on January 4 and 5.

He is coming to Nepal on an official visit to participate at a high-level Nepal-India Joint Commission between the two countries led by the foreign ministers. This mechanism reviews the bilateral relations between the two countries.

Spokesperson of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) Amrit Bahadur Rai said that the meeting of the bilateral mechanism would discuss the bilateral issues including economic cooperation and commerce.

Jaishankar is leading an Indian delegation at the seventh JC meeting scheduled to be held in Kathmandu. He is coming to Nepal after four years.

Meanwhile, to discuss the upcoming visit of his Indian counterpart and solicit suggestions for the preparation, Foreign Minister NP Saud held a dis

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One more Nepali confirmed dead in Russian war

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Jan. 2

Earlier, he had joined the Nepali Army but left his job after three years in service and reached Russia via Dubai.

A 23-year-old youth from Syangja, who joined the Russian army, has died. According to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA), Hari Prasad Aryal of Mankhu in Waling Municipality-14, died during the Russia-Ukraine war.

Earlier, he had joined the Nepali Army but left his job after three years in service and reached Russia via Dubai. Hari's family said that he went to Russia from Dubai, after a brief halt there, on October 3 last year.

Ward Chairman Bodhraj Kunwar (Raju) of Waling-14 informed that the ward office notified the family of Hari's death after the Department of Consular Services (DoCS) under the MoFA informed the ward office.

Kunwar said that the DoCS informed about the incident on December 28, 2023 while Hari had died on December 3.

Hari was unmarried and is survived by his parents, two brothers and two sisters-in-law. His brothers are in Dubai working in a company there. According to Kunwar, the brothers in Dubai said that they had already learned about the death of their brother. He said that his parents were not informed about the death of their son.

After enlisting in the Russian army, Hari was in constant contact with his family. The family said that they were in contact until a day before the incident.

Hari posted videos and pictures of him joining the army and walking with his friends on the social site Facebook.

Earlier, Pritam Karki of Putalibazar Municipality-5 of Syangja had died in Russia. Along with this, the number of Nepalis who lost their lives in Russian war after joining the Russian army from Syangja has reached two.

Annapurna region welcomes historic number of visitors in 2023

RAM BAHADUR THAPA/RSS
Gandaki, Jan 2

The Annapurna region welcomed 191,558 tourists in 2023, marking the highest number of visitors in its tourism history.

According to the Annapurna Conservation Area Project (ACAP), in 2019, the area witnessed the second-highest influx of tourists with 181,000 visitors. The latest surge in tourist arrivals indicates a remarkable recovery from the adverse impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic on the global tourism industry. The tourism industry, both in Nepal and globally, faced severe setbacks due to the COVID-19 pandemic.

Last year remained historic for Annapurna region in terms of the arrival of tourists, said ACAP chief Dr. Rabin Kadariya. The data indicates a rise in South Asian visitors, with 97,554 recorded in 2023 compared to 53,710 in 2019. Conversely, arrivals from other countries declined from 127,290 in 2019 to 94,004 in 2023.



It is said, the Annapurna region welcomed people from 173 countries: the highest number 96,187 from India followed by 8,526 from France, 7,641 from Germany, 7,249 from the United States of America, 7,174 from the UK and 6,323 from China.

It seems that tourism industry in the region has rebound after a significant fall during COVID-19. Amidst the pandemic, it recorded the arrivals of 16,105 tourists in 2021. However, this figure increased by more than eight folds to reach 129,733 in 2022. However, Dr. Kadariya expressed concerns about the diminishing charm of the region for European and American tourists. He attributed this to the expansion of roadway facilities, posing a threat to the Annapurna Circuit Trek. The recent developments in road infrastructure raise urgent calls to preserve the region's natural beauty and charm.

The region has been listed as one of the 10 best tourist destinations in the world.

Annapurna circuit trekking route encompasses various destinations including Annapurna Base Camp, Mardi Himal, Ghodepani, Tilicho Lake in Manang, Thorong-La Pass, Upper Mustang and the Muktinath region. It welcomes thousands of tourists from home and abroad each year. However, the ACAP keeps records of foreign tourists exploring these destinations.

According to Dr. Kadariya, it is challenging to accurately determine the number of domestic tourists but stated the arrivals soar significantly in the months of Asoj (September-October) and Kartik (October-November)

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NEA arranges tariff installment to the industries

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 2

The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) has arranged that consumers who consume electricity from dedicated and trunk lines can settle the tariff arrears in up to a maximum of 60 installments.

The meeting of the Board of Directors of the Authority held on Monday evening under the chairmanship of the Minister of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet increased the arrangement of installments to pay the outstanding amount.

Managing Director of NEA Kul Man Ghising said that a special arrangement has been made by the Board of Directors to facilitate installment payments for the same number of months or maximum 60 months for which the bill is issued.

In the past, in case of load-shedding, the customers of the industrial, businesses and non-commercial categories who took electricity supply from the dedicated feeder and trunk lines that continuously supplied electricity, were repeatedly requested through public notices for payment of electricity tariffs with premiums.



File Photo: TRN

After they ignored the NEA's request and refused to pay the tariff arrears, NEA started disconnecting the power supply from December 22, 2023, according to Electricity Distribution Regulations, 2078, clause 31 and Electricity Tariff Collection Regulations, 2078, clause 10.

In the past, common consumers were experiencing 17-18 hours of load shedding daily, while 239 industries and businesses and non-commercial customers were consuming more than 20 hours through dedicated feeders and trunk lines.

Out of 239 customers, 178 customers paid the electricity tariff to the Authority on time, including the premium for dedicated and trunk lines.

The total outstanding amount of 61 industries who consumed electricity from dedicated and trunk lines till mid-December 2023, is Rs. 22.24 billion, said the NEA.

Out of this, the electricity supply of 23 industries with arrears of more than Rs. 50 million have been cut. The Authority has a strategy of gradually disconnecting the lines of other industries that bear arrears.

Electricity of Himal Iron reconnected after payment of first installment

Himal Iron operating in Parwanipur under the Bara-Parsa Industrial Corridor, has started paying its arrears for electricity consumption from dedicated and trunk line. Manoj Silwal, Deputy Managing Director of Nepal Electricity Authority, said that Himal Iron paid Rs. 2.711 million for the first installment out of Rs. 81.2 million arrears.

Silwal said that the power line of this industry was connected at 9 o'clock on Monday night after the industry paid the first installment of dues. The Authority had cut the line of the industry on Friday. The industry has said that it will pay its outstanding amount in 36 installments.

Agri-machinery exhibition to begin in Pokhara on Friday

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 2

Agri-Mechinery Exhibition 2080, the first provincial level exhibition of agricultural machinery, technologies and innovations, is set to begin on Friday, January 5, 2024.

The three-day expo is being organised by the Nepal Agricultural Machinery Entrepreneurs Association (NAMEA) with the slogan of 'Adoption of mechanisation in agriculture, change in agricultural work'. It will be held at the Pokhara Exhibition Centre, Naya Bazaar, Pokhara from 5-8 January, and will open 10 AM to 5 PM.

The NAMEA had previously held expos of agricultural machinery and technology at the national level. From this time, the expo has been started at the provincial level as well, informed Krishna Sharma, President of the organisation.

The organiser said that the exhibition would provide information about modern technology, various agricultural tools and equipment and services in one place, and create awareness among policymakers and consumers about agricultural mechanisation technology.

It also aims to contribute to the promotion of technology and develop the internal market of agricultural technologies and services.

Other objectives of the exhibition are to increase the promotion of agricultural machinery and equipment and to assist in agricultural mechanisation, to coordinate between agricultural professionals and consumers, to increase awareness about commercial agricultural systems and to create investment opportunities.

National and international companies in the field including modern agriculture, animal husbandry, fisheries, floriculture, commercial vegetable cultivation and processing, marketing, modern devices, equipment and technology materials, seeds, and modern irrigation will participate in the exhibition, said Sharma.

SKT Nepal Pvt Ltd is the title sponsor of this regional exhibition, while G Seven Agriculture Pvt. Ltd, Muktinath Agricultural Company Limited, Krishi Bikas Bank Limited have also supported the event. Entry to the exhibition is free.

The first National Agricultural Mechanisation Exhibition was held in Narayangadh in Chitwan in 2070. Since then, this exhibition had been organised once each in Kohalpur in Banke, Bhrikutimandap in Kathmandu and Dharan in Sunsari and twice in Bharatpur of Chitwan.

Tourist arrival down in Lumbini



Photo: Laxman Paudel/TRN

Tourists wander near Maya Devi temple in Lumbini.

BY LAXMAN PAUDEL
Bhairahawa, Jan. 2

Despite strong figures at the national level, tourism in Gautam Buddha's birthplace of Lumbini has not recovered to pre-pandemic numbers yet. In 2019, the year before the COVID-19 entered Nepal, a total of 1,558,326 Nepali and foreign nationals came here. In 2023, only 998,938 did.

Lumbini saw almost no tourists in 2020 and 2021 due to the coronavirus outbreak. But, as the epidemic began to wane in 2022, visitor numbers started to climb. But they still have not reached the 2019 level.

This is because domestic tourists have seemed reluctant to return. 2019 saw 1,178,140 Nepalis come to Lumbini. But this number decreased by 45 per cent in 2023. Only 656,218 Nepalis visited last year.

Tourist arrivals from third countries (countries other than India) have also decreased by 56 per cent. A total of 174,015 third country-citizens arrived in Lumbini in 2019 while 76,210 arrived in 2023. These are the figures recorded around 2007. However, 2023 saw the highest Indian tourist arrivals on record. Lumbini welcomed 266,510 Indians last year, 230,863 in 2022 and 206,171 in 2019.

Meanwhile, the number of tourists viewing the third largest peak of the world, Kanchanjungha, also declined sharply owing to growing chill of late. Tourism entrepreneur Pema Sherpa informed that the area witnessed severe cold for some days, resulting into decline in tourists' arrival. However, they had not witnessed snowfall this year.

The hotel and lodges are closed after not getting visitors. The hoteliers of Kanchanjungha area have shifted down to Phungling, while some to Kathmandu city to avoid cold. The Kanchanjungha area had arrival of huge number of tourists before cold, according to Tasi Tenjing Sherpa, a person affiliated to the Kanchanjungha Conservation Area Management Council. "Since last Asoj to Poush, the area had recorded entry of 760 tourists from different countries. It was highest number of tourist inflow since the COVID-19," he reminded.

Sugarcane farmers receive subsidy

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, Jan. 2

The sugarcane farmers of Sarlahi have received the subsidy amount after one year. According to Kapil Muni Mainali, president of the Federation of Sugarcane Producers' Association, the subsidy amount has been received in the bank account of each sugarcane farmer.

The District Treasury Controller Office handed over the cheque of subsidy amount to the banks and financial institutions to deposit it to the concerned farmers' bank account last Thursday. Mainali said that banks have deposited money in the farmers' accounts.

According to him, the government has provided the subsidy amount of sugarcane sold by farmers a year ago only after the farmers organized a protest. Last year, when the price of sugarcane was fixed at Rs. 610 per quintal, it was decided that the industry would provide Rs. 540 per quintal and the government would provide Rs. 70 as a subsidy.

The government had released only around Rs. 110 million out of the total subsidy amount of Rs. 292 million that had to be provided to farmers of Sarlahi before Dashain festival. After the government had released insufficient amounts, farmers were paid at the rate of 30 per cent, i.e., at the rate of Rs. 21 per quintal out of Rs. 70.

With the government recently sending the remaining subsidy amount, the farmers have received their full amount of subsidy for the sale of sugar last year.



File photo: TRN

Nirmal Neupane, chief of District Treasury Controller Office, Sarlahi, said that every bank and financial institution was instructed to deposit the amount in the farmer's account immediately after handing over the cheque. "As the farmers were really upset when they did not get the subsidy for a year, we sent cheques to the banks asking them to deposit the money into the farmers' accounts immediately," Neupane said.

He asked the farmers to go to the bank where their subsidy money comes and find out whether the money has been deposited or not. The government has fixed the price of sugarcane at Rs. 635 per quintal for this year.

Out of the fixed price of sugarcane, the industrialists will provide Rs. 565 per quintal and the government will provide Rs. 70 as subsidy. As the government of Madhes Province has also announced an additional subsidy amount of Rs. 10 per quintal for this year, Mainali said that they would initiative to receive such subsidy amount.

'Chicken and Egg Festival' organised in Chitwan

RSS
Chitwan, Jan. 2

A 'Chicken and Egg Festival' has been organised on the occasion of the 11th National Poultry Day to explain the importance of chicken meat and egg.

Nepal Poultry Entrepreneurs' Forum organised the festival at Namaste Chowk of Bharatpur Metropolitan City-2 under the theme 'Variety of chicken meat and egg - Basis of healthy life' this year. Chicken meat and egg were distributed free of cost in the festival.

On the occasion, Vice-Chairperson of Nepal Poultry Federation, Tikaram Pokhrel, said consumption of chicken meat and egg has not increased for not being able to make people understand about the importance of chicken meat and egg. It would be fruitful if the importance of chicken meat and egg could be explained from school level, he mentioned. Similarly, Forum Chairperson Raghu Nath Bhatta shared that poultry entrepreneurs have been hit hard due to economic crisis seen in the country in recent period.

Stating that white meat is beneficial for health, he pointed out that it was necessary to make the people understand about its importance as it is useful for all types of patients. A week-long programme organised on the occasion of Day was also concluded. A total of 1,947 students of 26 community schools were explained about the importance of chicken meat and egg under the week-long programme.

Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal
CORPORATE PLANNING AND MONITORING DEPARTMENT
SINAMANGAL, KATHMANDU, NEPAL

Letter of Intent

Date of publication – January 3 , 2024 (2080/09/18)

Pursuant to the clause 27 (2) of Public Procurement Act, 2063, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive lowest evaluated bid has been selected to award the contract as per the Invitation for Bids published on The Rising Nepal dated Oct-16, 2023.

S.No	Name of Contract	Name & Address of Selected Bidder	Bid Amount
1	The Procurement of Smart Hall System for CAAN Building, Sinamangal (NCB-03-CPMD-2078/79).	M/S Cybernetics Pvt. Ltd.	NPR 92,76,622/- (Including VAT).

Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal
Corporate Planning and Monitoring Department
Sinamangal, Kathmandu, Nepal

Re-Invitation for Electronic Bids

Date of Publication: 2080/09/18 (January 3, 2024)

1. The Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal, Corporate Planning and Monitoring Department invites electronic bids for the following bids from eligible bidders under National Competitive Bidding procedures specified in Public Procurement Act and Regulations.

S. N.	Description of Work and Bid Notice No.	Bid Document Price	Bid Security Amount	Pre-Bid Meeting
1	The Procurement of IT Equipment for CAAN (NCB-01-CPMD-IT-080/81)	NRs. 3000 + VAT	NRs. 130000/-	NA

2. A set of Bid document shall be obtained from http://www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp within 15 days from the date of first publication of this notice and on receipt of a cash deposit (non-refundable) in NMB Bank, Babarmahal, Account No. 0010012611500043 of Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN).
3. Bidder shall submit the bid electronically. Electronic Bid must be submitted to the address http://www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp on or before 12:00 hour (NST) on the 16th day of the first publication of the Bid notice. Any Bid received after the above specified date and time will not be entertained.
4. Bids shall be opened at 14:00 hour (NST) on the 16th day, the last date of submission of Bid, in presence of the bidder or their authorized representatives who choose to attend or even in their absence at Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal, Sinamangal, Kathmandu. If the last date of Bid Document opening falls on a public holiday, then the next working day will be deemed as the due date but the time will be same as stipulated.
5. Bids must be valid for a period of 90 days from the date of bid opening and must be accompanied by a scanned copy of the bid security in pdf format which shall be valid for 30 days beyond the validity period of the bid or Bank Voucher of cash deposited at NIC Asia Bank, Thapathali, Account No. 5444050568352401 of Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal, Babarmahal, Kathmandu.
6. Any additional matters not covered by this shall be in accordance with the prevailing Procurement Act 2063 and Procurement Regulation 2064 of the GON.

Seti Provincial Hospital lacks ample manpower, equipment

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Attaria, Jan. 2



PHOTO: TRN

Seti Provincial Hospital established in Kailali in 1939 BS as a primary hospital is the only government referral hospital in Sudurpashchim Province.

Seti Provincial Hospital established in 1939 BS as a primary hospital is the only government referral hospital in Sudurpashchim Province.

Seti Provincial Hospital, upgraded from 25 beds to 50 beds during King Birendra's visit to the erstwhile Far Western Development Region in 1983, has received the approval to upgrade it to a 125-bed hospital from the then government.

The federal government upgraded the Seti Regional Hospital as a provincial-level hospital and handed it over to the provincial government in 2018. Although the hospital has completed 84 years of its establishment, the hospital still lacks the required manpower, infrastructure and equipment.

People of the Far Western region are often deprived of general health care, as they are not able to attain quality and convenient health services and facilities from government hospitals. People of this region still have to go to India for complex treatment, as there are situations where patients have to wait up to a year for an operation.

Due to the lack of permanent manpower in the hospital, doctors have been appointed on a contract and wage basis. Dr. Sher Bahadur Kamar, acting Medical Superintendent of Seti Provincial Hospital, said, "Owing to the surge in the number of patients, the hospital had been operating with a capacity of 302 beds before obtaining the approval of the government for the additional beds."

Kamar said that in the fiscal year 2022/23, the hospital treated 235,318 patients in the OPD. Although the permanent manpower in the hospital is only for 50 beds, the Hospital Development Committee has hired 75 additional manpower. The hospital has the manpower to operate only 125 beds and 14 departments.

"Seti Provincial Hospital caters Surgery Department, Medicine-Cardio Department, Paediatric Department, Orthopaedic Department, Obstetrics Department, Dermatology Department, Anaesthesia, Ear, Nose and Throat (ENT) Department, Dental Department, Emergency Department, Radiology Department, Forensic Department, Pathology and Mental Disease Department," informed Kamar.

There are 36 beds for medicine, 48 beds for surgery, 30 beds for paediatrics and NICU, and 75 beds for obstetrics available at the hospital. Similarly, there are an additional 20 beds in the emergency room, 15 beds in observation, 15 beds in ICU, four beds in HDU, 20 beds in dialysis, 10 beds in NRH, one bed in the cabin, nine beds in NICU and 20 beds in the proposed post-operation ward.

There is a shortage of radiologists and anaesthesiologists in the hospital. Although an anaesthesiologist is needed for surgery and a radiologist is needed for diagnosis, only two radiologists and anaesthesiologists are working in the hospital. The hospital said that despite advertising for radiologists and anaesthesiologists, no application was received.

Dr. Kamar informed that the hospital currently has 367 human resources including permanent staff and those working on a contract and wage basis.

"The hospital needs at least 770 employees to function at the full scale. This hospital's main challenge is lack of manpower and equipment," said Kamar.

Even though the provincial government has plans to upgrade the hospital to 200 beds, the Management Survey has not yet been conducted. The construction of the hospital building has not been completed.

Nar Bahadur Shah, Chairman of the Hospital Development Committee, said that the hospital was facing problems in catering services at present. Still, new hospital buildings are being constructed without providing the minimum number of manpower.

The Ministry of Social Development has said that the hospital improvement and upgrading work has begun from the upgradation of Seti Provincial Hospital.

Jhapat Bahadur Saud, Social Development Minister of the Sudurpashchim Province, said that the ministry has started the work of improving and upgrading the hospital of the Province starting from Seti Provincial Hospital.

Minister Saud said that the Organisation and Management Survey of Seti Provincial Hospital would be conducted within the current fiscal year.

"The plan has been moved forward to establish a medical college in Seti Hospital. The goal is to teach paramedics, MDs and MS soon," Saud said.

Chhare locals using rickety suspension bridge

BY RAJAN RAWAT
Humla, Jan. 2



PHOTO: RAJAN RAWAT/TRN

As seen in this picture, the locals of Chhare, situated on the border of Kharpunath and Sarkegad Rural Municipalities, and beasts are compelled to cross the Karnali River through a rickety suspension bridge.

Locals of Chhare, situated on the border of Kharpunath and Sarkegad Rural Municipalities, are compelled to cross the Karnali River through a rickety suspension bridge.

The bridge has been in a dilapidated condition after a few wooden planks weakened and collapsed. However, to allow locals and mules to cross it, the damaged sections were covered up with stones.

Jagat Viyal, who has been transporting goods from Syaltadi of Sarkegad Rural Municipality-6, said that although the suspension bridge of Chhare was in a very dilapidated condition, people and mules carrying goods were forced to use it risking their lives.

He said that the wooden planks on the bridge had decayed, causing some of the nails embedded in the wood to come loose, resulting in substantial holes in the structure. So, crossing the bridge has become problematic for both people and animals.

It is difficult for pedestrians to walk on the 50-year-old suspension bridge. On top of that, it is even more difficult to move mules carrying up to 70 kg of goods. Most of the nails fixed on wooden planks placed on the 100-metre-long bridge have gone missing, as a result, they move whenever someone walks on it.

Just a few days ago, one of the mules broke its leg after it got caught in a gap on the bridge.

Situated on the border of two rural municipalities, the bridge has undergone several repairs in the past, attesting to the insistent need for maintenance. Kharpunath Rural Municipality Chairman Karna Bahadur Rawal has said that the rural municipality is in the process of repairing the bridge. With no alternative available, the pedestrians crossing the Karnali River have to fully on the risky bridge.

Three model houses handed over; 21 under construction

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rukum West, Jan. 2

Earthquake-resilient model houses built in Pharula village of Chaurjahari Municipality-6 in Rukum West district have been handed over to the quake victims whose houses were destroyed by the earthquake of November 3 last year.

Mayor Pushpa Badi handed over three houses to the victims' families during a programme.

Mayor Badi handed over the houses by providing the keys of the houses at a function held on Tuesday. The houses were built for locals Kali Bahadur Kami, Kamal BK and Shashi Bohora. Warm clothes were also provided to the three families.

In the programme, Mayor Badi said that the party under the leadership of former mayor Bishal Sharma, who is also a central member of CPN (Maoist Centre), had done exemplary work by building the model houses.

Badi mentioned that all political parties needed to conduct similar campaigns during calamities. He said that the work would convey a positive message and said that the model houses were built by adding some money from his pocket to the grant money provided by the government.

Former mayor Sharma, who led the construction of model earthquake-resistant houses, said that 16 members of three families, who had been spending cold nights under the tarpaulins for two months, would now be able to sleep in safe houses.

Sharma said that he felt happy after building the houses for the poor families who were rendered homeless in the earthquake.

Of the four model houses, whose construction began in mid-November last year, three have been completed so far. It is said that the house of local Chandra Budhathoki will be ready in the next 15 days.

According to Sharma, they spent Rs. 481,321 to build the three model houses. A total of 583 locals worked as volunteer labourers for the construction of the houses.

The federal government has provided Rs. 150,000 for the construction of three model houses while Rajan Khatiwada of Dhading provided Rs. 25,000. Likewise, the Chief of Chaurjahari Hospital, Dil Bahadur Giri gave Rs. 50,000, Jaharikhola Cooperatives Rs. 25,000, and Lokendra Devkota of Chaurjahari-12 donated Rs. 25,000 to build the houses. Likewise, each of the three families managed Rs. 35,000 and the remaining cost was borne by Sharma.

Meanwhile, the construction of an earthquake-resistant integrated model settlement has started in Takuritole of Chaurjahari Municipality-12 in Rukum West.

Mayor Badi laid the foundation stone for the construction of an earthquake-resistant integrated model settlement. A total of 21 houses will be built in the settlement simultaneously.

According to former mayor Sharma, the victims' families and human development and community services will jointly invest for the construction of the settlement.

Sharma said that the concerned parties have agreed to invest about Rs. 500,000 each for the construction of the settlement.

FINAL RITES OF JOURNALIST POKHAREL PERFORMED

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 2

The final rites of senior journalist and former Acting General Manager of the Rastriya Samachar Samiti (RSS), Gokul Prasad Pokharel, have been performed at Pashupati Aryaghat.

His son Anup Pokharel lit the funeral pyre. Late Pokharel is survived by a wife, a son and two daughters.

Journalist Pokharel passed away on Monday in course of treatment at Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital at the age of 87.

Born at Kochinde of Dhankuta in 1993 BS, he was suffering from lung problems.

He was former member of National Human Rights Commission, founding General-Secretary of the Nepal Press Institute (NPI) as well as its President for two tenures.

He also served as Editor of Gorkhapatra Daily and founding Chief Editor of Muna, children's magazine.

Spinal Trauma Centre comes into operation in Birtamod

RSS
Jhapa, Jan. 2

A trauma facility has been established in Biratmod which has, of late, been developed as a 'hospital hub'.

The 15-bed Spine X Super Specialty Hospital and Trauma Centre has come into operation at Bhagwanchowk of Birtamod-3.

Hospital proprietor and senior orthopaedic specialist Dr. Prem Bahadur Shahi claimed the facility was the country's first specialised facility for spine injuries.

The preliminary investment of the hospital is Rs. 300 million.

The hospital management plans to extend it to a hundred-bed facility in a year.

It said the rate of orthopaedic injuries is high during road accidents and it is challenging to save lives in lack of prompt treatment. Shahi pledged to provide quality services in an accessible way for the public.

It offers services such as keyhole surgery, joint replacements, complex trauma surgery, bone biopsy, limb re-plantation, and so on.

Before this, Birtamod has around a dozen of advanced hospitals including a cancer hospital operated by the private sector.

The emergence of such healthcare facilities provides viable alternatives for patients who, until a decade ago, were compelled to seek specialised treatments in India, it is said.

Notice for Intent to award the contract

(Date of Publication 3 January, 2024)

Pursuant to sub clause 27.2 and 27.3 of Public Procurement Act 2063, this is to notify all concerned bidders that it is our intention to award the contract to the following bidder for the Tender Notice No. KSCL/U/ICB-157/080/081 for Supply and Delivery of 30,000±2% MT of Urea as per the Invitation for Bids published on 31 October, 2023 in 'The Rising Nepal' & www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp as it is found substantially responsive and lowest evaluated bidder.

Tender Notice No.	Name of the successful bidder	Bidder rate in USD	Total Amount
KSCL/U/ICB-157/080/081	M/S Indian Potash Limited, New Delhi, India	CIP Birgunj - / CIP Biratnagar - / CIP Bhairahawa - } 449.88	USD 1,34,96,400.00

KRISHI SAMAGRI COMPANY LTD.
Procurement Department, Head Office
Kathmandu, Nepal, Tel : (+9771) 5374819
E-mail: aicl.nepal@gmail.com

Hydro Support Pvt. Ltd.
Kathmandu, Nepal

Invitation for Expression of Interest (EOI) for Short Listing

Hydro Support Pvt. Ltd. (HSPL) intends to develop Middle Kaligandaki Hydro Electric Project (MKGHEP) in Myagdi District and invites Expression of Interest (EOI) from interested, eligible and experienced domestic contractors (if in JV not more than two partners) who fulfill the following basic criterion. Contractors are requested to submit EOI along with documents showing company legal status, financial resources, work experience, annual turnover, equipment owned and manpower for short listing.

Works	Minimum Criterion
MKGHEP-Civil-01	1. Completed as a prime contractor construction of 25 MW size hydropower project and tunnel more than 3 km in the last 3 years. 2. Having minimum average annual construction turnover of NRs. 3.6 billion in the best three years in the last five years. 3. Should own following equipment but not limited to: Concrete batching plants of 25m3/hr - 2 Nos., Crusher of 50m3/hr - 1 Nos., Transit mixture (TM) of capacity 6 m3 - 2 Nos., Self-loading TM of capacity 3m3 - 2 Nos. , Drilling jumbo - 2 Nos., Robotic shotcrete machines. - 2 Nos., Haggloadder - 1 Nos. and 300LC Excavator - 1 Nos. 4. Having sufficient financial resourses, capability of arranging additional construction equipment and appropriate manpower to complete the work in the stipulated time.

The Expression of Interest document in sealed envelope and clearly marked ***"Expression of Interest for short listing for Middle Kaligandaki HEP Civil Works"*** should be submitted on or before 17.00 hours on 14 January 2024 to the HSPL office, 548 Buddhi Sagar Marga, Panipokhari, Kathmandu, Nepal (email: hspl.hep@gmail.com tel. +14002801).

The EOI document received after the due date and time shall be rejected. HSPL reserves its right to accept or reject any proposal, or call off the entire process, without assigning any reason whatsoever.

Executive Director

Eye centre established in Arjun Municipality



PHOTO: ARJUN KAFLE/TRN

Locals of Arjun Chaupari Rural Municipality in Syangja are delighted with the establishment of an eye treatment centre near their homes, and are receiving treatment.

BY ARJUN KAFLE
Syangja, Jan. 2

Locals of Arjun Chaupari Rural Municipality in the district are delighted with the establishment of an eye treatment centre near their homes.

The eye treatment centre has been set up at the office building of the rural municipality in collaboration with the Netrajyoti Association, Himalaya Eye Hospital and the rural municipality.

Nandrakala Devkota, a 76-year-old local, said the Rural Municipality has done a good job by opening the eye treatment centre.

She said that because of her poor financial condition, she was unable to go to the cities for cataract treatment. "Now, the treatment centre has been set up in the village," she said. It is the first eye treatment centre in Syangja district and the third in Gandaki Province after Jaimani and Bholchhar eye centres.

The Eye Care Foundation has provided equipment worth Rs. 1 million to establish the eye centre.

Prakash Tiwari, chairman of Arjun Chaupari Rural Municipality, said that the eye centre was inaugurated in the municipality building so that the people could easily get the treatment service.

He said that one could get treatment facilities on all office days free of cost.

He said that the municipality would provide free surgery services to the residents of the rural municipality who could not afford to pay for treatment.

Dr. Ilia Shrestha, Director of the Himalayan Eye Hospital, said that the eye treatment centre has been established in the initiative of the rural municipality.

It is said that 80 per cent of eye patients could receive treatment services from the centre.

The Himalaya Eye Hospital has managed technicians while the rural municipality has arranged other services.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

The best preparation for tomorrow is doing your best today.
-- H. Jackson Brown, Jr.

EDITORIAL

Create Employment

Nepal currently stands at the crucial junction of economic challenges, marked by growing dissatisfaction within the private sector. The recent dispute over dedicated electricity supply and sluggish market demand has brought to the forefront the imperative need for collaborative solutions. The Finance Ministry's commitment to open dialogue represents a positive step towards aligning governmental efforts with the needs of the private sector. However, a closer examination of the economic status reveals critical issues that necessitate comprehensive attention for sustainable growth. The call of Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat for stakeholders to express their concerns, either in writing or through direct communication, underscores a dedication to collective issue resolution.

If implemented effectively, this approach holds the potential to foster a cooperative relationship between the government and the private sector, recognising the significance of unified action to overcome economic obstacles. Despite positive indicators such as reduced inflation, a buoyant stock market, and increased real estate transactions, Nepal faces challenges that impede long-term development. A notable hurdle is the state of poor infrastructure, particularly in the tourism sector. While the commitment to prioritise strategic projects and allocate budgets is commendable, success is contingent on efficient implementation and the resolution of bureaucratic hurdles.

Meanwhile, a concerning trend is the rise in the number of Nepali youths seeking opportunities abroad, posing a potential threat to the nation's future. With many students pursuing education overseas and a steady outflow of skilled labourers, urgent measures are necessary to retain talents within the country. The government must recognise the urgency of this brain drain and take concrete steps to encourage skilled individuals to contribute to domestic growth. Creating a thriving environment with ample job opportunities is imperative for all three-tier governments to retain the vibrant youth within the country. Addressing the concerns of this energetic demographic not only fosters their engagement but also encourages their collaboration with governments, propelling the nation towards a trajectory of development and prosperity.

Recent events in Nepal's foreign employment sector have brought pressing concerns to light, demanding prompt reforms. The incident last Friday, marked by mismanagement and unethical practices, has highlighted vulnerabilities in the system. Aspiring migrant workers face challenges that require a comprehensive review and immediate reforms to ensure their safety and fair treatment. Instilling trust among the business community requires not only a crucial call for confidence-building but also the implementation of specific measures. The promise of additional protective measures for Nepali industries is encouraging, but stakeholders need detailed plans for tangible impact. Amid these multifaceted challenges, a constructive and positive debate is vital.

Shifting the narrative from pessimism to proactive problem-solving requires collaboration from industrialists, civil society, and the media. All stakeholders must engage in a unified effort to identify and implement solutions. In conclusion, Nepal stands at an economic crossroads, facing challenges that demand a collaborative response. The Finance Ministry's commitment to open communication is promising, but actions must go beyond rhetoric. Focusing on strategic investments, infrastructure development, and retaining the potential of the country's youth is imperative. Only through determined efforts can Nepal pave the way for sustainable economic growth and a brighter future.

2023 In Retrospect

DIXYA POUDEL

2024 has arrived, a brand new year full of potential and promises. As such, it might help to look back at the year 2023, and assess it in hindsight. There are always lessons to be learned from the past, which can then be reassessed for future endeavours. From Twitter becoming X, the continuing of Russia-Ukraine war, Barbenheimer shaking the global box-office, death of prominent celebrities like Tina Turner, multiple charges to the former US president Donald Trump, the horrendous Israel-Hamas war, and the successful lunar landing by Indian spacecraft to the rise of AI (Artificial Intelligence), the year 2023 had quite a few highlights. However, it can be clearly said that the most devastating event of 2023 was the ambush that Hamas fired upon unsuspecting Israel which led to a war amid colossal destructions.

Closer to home in Nepal, there was varying news. Nepali cricket team set records, a 6.4 Richter scale earthquake jolted western Nepal, an agitation took over pro-monarchy supporters, and remittance hit an all record high in a month as Nepali youths continued their mass exodus. Likewise, Tribhuvan University conferred degrees to a record number of graduated students, and even set the Guinness World Record. Nepal also elected its new president. However, on a tragic note, there were many casualties from the natural disasters such as flood, landslide, and earthquake.

As for the world news, India landed its spacecraft on the south pole of the moon, a feat that made history. In the movie industry, disgruntled Hollywood writers went on strike on May, 2023 and only reached an agreement on September. The strike was partly due to irregularity on streaming platforms and the increasing use of AI. As such, 2023 was a glorious year for AI. OpenAI might have released ChatGPT in 2022 but it was really in 2023 that AI rose to its heights, leading people to speculate on the consequences. Heated debates ensued on the effects of AI in the job market. 2023 was also a good year for the arts and culture, particularly books, music, and movies. There were numerous groundbreaking books, fiction and nonfiction, which were published amid much acclaim. Like each year, in 2023 too the Booker Prize was announced and the Prize went to Paul Lynch for his novel, Prophet Song.

Meanwhile, nations turned a new page after the previous years of pandemic. While the world did recover, there were lingering economic effects from the pandemic. People still continued to work remotely whenever possible in 2023 as work from home appealed to a lot of them. But overall, many workers had to return to their office with the virtual lockdown still in their mind.

On the technological front, social media continued its meteoric rise albeit with several changes. Meta which is parent company of Facebook and Instagram rolled out a new social media platform called Threads. On the other hand, TikTok got banned by numerous countries including Nepal citing disruption of social harmony. And Twitter rebranded itself as X, leading to a different era for the social media app.

These are just some of the highlights of 2023. How time has flown by, leaving its mark behind for generations to come! As the world strides on a new year, let's hope 2024 will be more agreeable one.

Government's Report Card

Yuba Nath Lamsal



"A problem well stated is a problem half solved" goes the adage. In exactly similar manner, Prime Minister Puspa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has clearly stated the problems of the country and duly highlighted the issues he has taken up in the last one year in office. In an address to the nation on the completion of one year in office, Prime Minister Prachanda has made frank confession of not being fully able to live up to the expectations of the people and address all pressing problems facing the country in the last one year of his government. His remarks point to the honesty and sincerity to the nation and the people.

The period of one year is a long time to set the tone for speeding up the actions. At the same time, the one year is not long enough to show concrete results of all ills and evils that have engulfed the nation. But the government has set the direction towards which it seeks to move. It is true that the government has not been able to do what it should have been but it has initiated some positive and praiseworthy steps which need to be well taken of.

Bouncing economy

The government has identified problems of the country. Now is the time to use right tools to address these problems. The tools include right policies, right action, right time and right persons to handle these issues. It is said 'if your only tool is a hammer then every problem looks like a nail'. Problem identification is the first step but applying wrong tool to address the problem does not serve the purpose. Prachanda-led government has diagnosed the disease and now needs right prescription and right treatment, which alone can cure the disease.

The full term of a government, in principle, is five years as per the constitution. In every five year, elections are generally held barring a few exceptions. However, no government has so far completed its full five-year term in Nepal's modern history. Moreover, the present government is a coalition one as no single party has the working majority in parliament. Thus, coalition government is our fait accompli. We have adopted a mix of first-past-the post and proportionate electorate system which does not generally allow a single party to win majority seats in parliament to form the single-party government. Thus, different parties have to make compromise to form and give continuity to the government. The present government headed by Prachanda is a coalition of different parties. It is not certain how long this government will last. Thus, the period of one year is sufficient time to set the tone for action-oriented government and it has, to a large extent, taken necessary steps towards right direction.

Leading a coalition government comprising parties of different ideological and political orientation is definitely not a walk in the park. Prachanda knows this well and is walking tightrope managing diverse interests of coalition partners. In the last one year of his government, Prachanda has duly managed the coalition partners which, in itself, is an achievement. Otherwise, the country would fall into a cycle of political instability and uncertainty.

Over the last one year, we have seen some visible changes in various sectors. When the present government was formed, country's economy was in an awful state. Now the economy has seen a sign of improvement, thanks to some policy intervention and other measures. Bank liquidity is satisfactory. Remittance is encouraging. Foreign currency reserve is all time high which is adequate for the import of goods and services for 16 months. Private sector's confidence is reviving. Tourism sector has bounced back as last year saw more than one million foreign tourists. The government has been tough in corruption control and has initiated action to ensure good governance. Prime Minister has vowed to ensure effective, efficient and result-oriented administration for which he has already initiated some steps.

> The next few years are very crucial for Nepal as it is in the process of graduating from the status of the least developed country.

In the foreign policy and diplomatic front, the government's action and activities seem to be on the right track, barring a few lacunas. Given Nepal's geographic location and international geopolitical scenario, Nepal has to walk tightrope diplomacy. Nepal does not have luxury to make adventurous move in the international relation on whim and sentiment or align with any country or join in any kind of strategic and security alliance. 'Amity with all and enmity to none' is what we believe in the conduct of our international relations and diplomacy. We are surrounded by two powerful neighbours—one is already a world power and the other is in the making. Being immediate neighbours, China and India are definitely important for us. Similarly, the United States is lone superpower with which Nepal has always attached greater importance. Apart from these three powers, Nepal has maintained equally close, cordial and cooperative relations with several other countries and has, accordingly, conducted its foreign policy and diplomacy. The government has been able to win trust of our neighbours and all international friends and development partners.

Agreements

Prime Minister Prachanda paid official visit to India and China and reached some important agreements with both the countries having far reaching impact on the bilateral relations and development of Nepal. Similarly, he visited Italy in July to address the UN Food Systems Summit while he travelled to the United States and addressed UN General Assembly where he raised some pertinent issues facing Nepal and the rest of the world. In the COP28 held in Dubai of United Arab Emirates, Prime Minister's voice was loud and clear on climate change issue and its consequences for human survival. His call to support Nepal in saving the Himalayas was well appreciated by the international community. UN Secretary General António Guterres' visit and his commitment to support Nepal on climate issue is yet another diplomatic feather in government's hat.

The next few years are very crucial for Nepal as it is in the process of graduating from the status of the least developed country, achieving sustainable development goals set by the United Nations and climbing up to the level of middle income country. The support and contribution from our neighbours, international friends and development partners is even more imperative. Prime Minister Prachanda knows it well and has accordingly mobilised international support winning trust of all friends and partners. The report card of the government over the last one year is, therefore, above average or B-Plus.

(The author is former ambassador and former chief editor of this daily. lamsalyubanath@gmail.com)

Winning Justice Can Be A Hard Struggle

Namrata Sharma



INSIGHT

As the year 2023 ended, one of the best news that emerged in Nepal was the judgement that the 23-year-old famous cricketer of Nepal, Sandeep Lamichhane, was found guilty of raping a girl Gaushala-26 (name of victim not revealed). His sentencing has been fixed for 10th January 2024, and he can face up to 10 years in prison. The relief expressed by the victim was worth all the suffering she faced, but she is determined to prove that she was a minor when the crime against her took place.

Discrepancy

Nepal has witnessed a series of accusations by girls and women of different ages of being raped by men of high profile. Unfortunately, most of these cases get dissipated over the years and the victims do not get justice when they face one of the most heinous crimes against them because of their gender. In this case, after a year, the never tiring Gaushala-26 has received justice but has said she will continue to raise the case until it is proven that she is a minor. Due to some discrepancy in her birth date, her claim of being a minor when she was raped, could not be establish in the court. Nevertheless, the court said that as there was no consent, Lamichhane has been proven to be guilty of committing rape by taking advantage of her weak financial condition.

Nepal has a system of fast-track court judgments when crimes like rape happens and victims seek justice. However, in this case, there were repeated delays in the trial. Lamichhane was arrested in 2022 after he was accused and was imprisoned. He was then granted bail and released. The international cricket fraternity disowned him and the Nepal Cricket team removed him as the captain of the team. This step was welcomed by rights activists. However, after he received a bail, he also got a court ruling that he could continue to play for Nepal during several international cricket competitions including the last world cup.

There were several feats claimed by the Nepal cricket team and Lamichhane was part of the achievements. This has raised a serious question on the intention of allowing an accused player to represent Nepal in international tournaments. Scotland's cricketers refused to shake hands with him after a match and there has been a lot of anger against him together with surprise that he was actually allowed to participate in international matches by the bench of Judge Sapana Malla Pradhan, who has been crucial in amending and promulgating several gender favourable laws in the country.

> Nepal now has laws that support the rights of the minorities and marginalised populations together with victims of gender-based violence.

On 29th December 2023, a bench of District Court Judge Shishirraj Dhakal pronounced Lamichhane guilty. This has given a message that just because some people have talents of being good sportsperson does not give them the license of taking advantage of the vulnerabilities of girls. The cricket fans who cheered Lamichhane even after knowing that he had been accused of rape by a minor, need to reflect on their value system. The celebrity men who have become achievers in the field of sports, music, art or movies should not be given a power to suppress people.

Nepal now has laws that support the rights of the minorities and marginalised populations together with victims of gender-based violence. Unfortunately, accessing and asserting these rights are still a far-fetched reality because most of the times the perpetrators happen to be influential and the victims vulnerable.

Support

After the recent justice given by the court, the victim Gaushala-26 said that she had to live like a criminal just because she decided to be courageous enough to seek justice, while the perpetrator was being applauded. Like most girls and women who come out in the open after they have been raped or even molested and sexually abused, fingers start getting pointed at them as if they were the "bad girls and women" and the perpetrators are given the benefit of the doubt. The victims bear verbal and physical abuses to make them feel as if they are at fault rather than them getting love, support and justice. The mental trauma that victims like Gaushala-26 face while the crime happens point to the facts that only the victims know what it is like. In the majority of such cases, justice is denied, therefore the victims and their family refuse to go to the court.

It is important not only for the government to bring laws to safeguard daughters of Nepal, but for the Nepali society to make sure the streets are safe for them and not a place for men to make it a place where they can commit crimes and walk scot-free.

(Sharma is a senior journalist and women rights advocate and can be reached at namrata1964@yahoo.com X handle: @NamrataSharmaP)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 3, 1974

Nepalese Delegation Meets Indian Minister

Kathmandu, Jan. 2: The visiting Nepalese delegation led by Industry and Commerce Secretary called on Indian Commerce Minister Mr. D.P.Chattopadhya in New Delhi today, says RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Safer Way To Transport Bamboo



The news '*Keeping life afloat rowing bamboos down Saptakoshi River*' your prestigious daily published on Tuesday sheds light on the remarkable resourcefulness of the communities along the Saptakoshi River. But, at the same time, it showed the risks they have to endure to make a living.

As the monsoon ends and winter arrives, the people of Bhojpur, Dhankuta, Udayapur, Khotang and other hilly districts along the Saptakoshi River begin collecting bamboo, skilfully tie them into makeshift rafts and row them to Sunsari. This annual endeavour transforms the riverbanks into a bustling scene of determination.

But while we may commend the courage of the people involved in this trade, we must not ignore the dangers they put themselves in. Taking on the mighty Koshi on dingy bamboo skiffs can result in death. So, local communities must find a safer way to transport bamboo while keeping their livelihood intact. The concerned local governments may offer assistance for this too.

Prakash Shrestha
Chitwan

TAILPIECE

A guy goes into a bar and orders a beer. As he takes a sip of his beer, he hears a tiny little voice say: "Nice tie." He looks around but sees no one. He take another sip of his beer and hears: "A nice shirt, too." Again he looks around and sees no one.

He signals the bartender over, and hesitantly explains that he's hearing voices talking to him... "Of course," smiles the bartender. "It's the peanuts -- they're complimentary."

"Mr. Clark, I'm afraid I have bad news," the doctor told his anxious patient. "You only have six months to live."

The man sat in stunned silence for the next several minutes. Regaining his composure, he apologetically told his physician that he had no medical insurance. "I can't possibly pay you in that time."

"Okay," the doctor said, "let's make it nine months."

Japan earthquake death toll reported at least 48



PHOTO: AP

Houses fallen by an earthquake are seen in Kanazawa, Ishikawa prefecture, Japan Tuesday, Jan. 2, 2024.

AP
Japan, Jan. 2

A series of powerful earthquakes that hit western Japan have left at least 48 people dead and damaged thousands of buildings, vehicles and boats. Officials warned that more quakes could lie ahead.

Aftershocks continued to shake Ishikawa prefecture and nearby areas a day after a magnitude 7.6 temblor slammed the area on Monday afternoon.

Forty-eight people were confirmed dead in Ishikawa, officials said. Sixteen others were seriously injured, while damage to homes was so great that it could not immediately be assessed, they said.

Japanese media reports said tens of thousands of homes were destroyed. Government spokesperson Yoshimasa Hayashi said 17 people were seriously injured and gave a slightly lower death tally, while saying he was aware of the prefecture's tally.

Water, power and cell phone service were still down in some areas, and residents expressed sorrow about their destroyed homes and uncertain futures.

"It's not just that it's a mess. The wall has collapsed, and you can see through to the next room. I don't think we can live here anymore," Miki Kobayashi, an Ishikawa resident, said as she swept around her house.

Their house was also damaged in a 2007 quake, she said.

Although casualty numbers continued to climb gradually, the prompt public warnings, relayed on broadcasts and phones, and the quick response from the general public and officials appeared to have kept at least some of the damage under control.

The rescue efforts that quickly followed from firefighters, police and the military proved a testament to how this nation has repeatedly withstood disasters, which have practically become a part of everyday life.

Toshitaka Katada, a University of Tokyo professor specializing in disasters, said the people were prepared because the area had been hit by quakes in recent years. They had evacuation plans and emergency supplies in stock.

"There is probably no people on earth other than Japanese who are so disaster-ready," he said in a telephone interview with The Associated Press.

Katada warned the situation remains precarious and unpredictable. The March 2011 quake and tsunami in northeastern Japan had been preceded by other quakes.

"This is far from over," Katada said.

Predictions by scientists have repeatedly been proven wrong, such as with the 2016 quake in southwestern Kumamoto, an area previously seen as relatively quake-free. The only real projection possible is that you can't make projections, Katada added.

"Having too much confidence in the power of science is very dangerous. We are dealing with nature."

Japanese media aerial footage showed widespread damage in the hardest-hit spots, with landslides burying roads, boats tossed in the waters and a major fire that had turned an entire section of Wajima city to ashes.

Japan's military dispatched 1,000 soldiers to the disaster zones to join rescue efforts, Prime Minister Fumio Kishida said Tuesday.

"Saving lives is our priority and we are fighting a battle against time," he said. "It is critical that people trapped in homes get rescued immediately."

Russian ballistic missiles strike Ukraine's largest cities

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Jan. 2

Ukraine's two largest cities came under attack from Russian hypersonic ballistic missiles on Tuesday morning, killing at least four people and injuring almost 100, officials said, as the war approached its two-year milestone and the Kremlin's forces stepped up their winter bombardment of urban areas.

Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on his Telegram channel that four civilians were killed and 92 injured in the capital, Kyiv, and in northeastern Kharkiv as hypersonic Kinzhal missiles that can fly at 10 times the speed of sound slammed into city blocks.

Since Sunday, Zelenskyy said, the Kremlin's forces have launched about 170 Shahed drones and "dozens of missiles of various types" against Ukrainian targets. Most were aimed at civilian areas, he said.

The Kh-47M2 Kinzhal is an air-launched hypersonic ballistic missile. Russian forces rarely use such expensive missiles against Ukraine due to their limited stocks.

The attacks created a desolate morning scene in the capital, with most cafes and restaurants remaining closed. Many people opted to stay indoors or seek refuge in shelters as powerful explosions shook the city from early morning.

Air raid sirens blared for nearly four hours, and the city's subway stations — which function as shelters — were crowded with people.

After the Ukrainian air force issued warnings about incoming hypersonic missiles, people wearing pajamas underneath their coats took sleeping bags, mats and their pets to subway stations while loud explosions echoed above the city. At one of the central stations, called Golden Gates, hundreds of people filled the spacious underground areas while trains continued to run.



PHOTO: AP

Fire and smoke rises after a Russian attack in Kyiv, Ukraine, Tuesday, Jan. 2, 2024.

"Perhaps today was the most frightening because there were so many explosions," said Myroslava Shcherba, 55.

The barrage extended Russia's escalated attacks on Ukraine that began Friday with its largest single assault on Ukraine since the war started, in which at least 41 civilians were killed.

The next day, shelling of the Russian border city of Belgorod killed more than two dozen people. Russia blamed Ukraine for the attack and has struck back repeatedly since.

The attack on Belgorod was one of the deadliest to take place on Russian soil since Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine started more than 22 months ago. Russian officials said the death toll stood at 25 as of Monday, including five children.

Cities across western Russia have regularly come under drone attacks since May, although Ukrainian officials never acknowledge responsibility for strikes on Russian territory or the Crimean Peninsula.

"They want to intimidate us and create uncertainty within our country. We will intensify strikes. Not a single crime against our civilian population will go unpunished," Putin said Monday, describing the barrage of Belgorod as a "terrorist act."

Russia launched about 90 Shahed-type drones across Ukraine on Monday.

SKorean opposition leader is stabbed in the neck

AP
South Korea, Jan 2

South Korea's tough-speaking liberal opposition leader, Lee Jae-myung, was stabbed in the neck by an unidentified knife-wielding man who attempted to kill him during his visit to the southeastern city of Busan, police said.

Lee, 59, the head of the main opposition Democratic Party, was airlifted to a Seoul hospital for surgery after receiving emergency treatment in Busan. Police and emergency officials earlier said he was conscious after the attack and wasn't in critical condition, but his exact status was unknown.

The attack happened as Lee walked through a crowd of journalists and others after a tour of the proposed site of a new airport in Busan. The attacker approached Lee, saying he wanted to get his autograph, and then stabbed him in the left side of his neck with a knife, senior Busan police officer Sohn Jae-han said in a televised briefing.

Sohn said Democratic Party officials near Lee quickly subdued the attacker before police officers detained him. He said 41 police officers had been deployed to the area for crowd control and traffic management.

TV footage showed Lee, his eyes closed, lying on the ground as a person pressed a handkerchief to his neck to stop the bleeding. A witness, Jin Jeonghwa, told YTN television that Lee had bled a lot. Videos circulated on social media showed the suspect, wearing a paper crown reading "I'm Lee Jae-myung," being chased and tackled by several people, apparently including plainclothes police officers.

Sohn said the suspect, aged about 67, told investigators that he bought the 18-centimeter (7-inch) knife online. He said police are investigating the motive for the attack. Other officers said police are expected to request that the suspect be formally arrested for alleged attempted murder because he told investigators he intended to kill Lee.

Lee's Democratic Party called the incident "a terrorist attack on Lee and a serious threat to democracy." It called on police to make a through, swift investigation.

At Pusan National University Hospital in Busan, where Lee received emergency treatment, party spokesperson Kwon Chil-seung said Lee's jugular vein was believed to have been damaged and there was concern over the large amount of bleeding. Hospital officials would not comment on Lee's condition.

President Yoon Suk Yeol expressed deep concern about Lee's health and ordered authorities to investigate the attack, saying such violence would not be tolerated, according to Yoon's office.

Lee faces an array of corruption allegations, including that he provided unlawful favors to a private investor who reaped huge profits from a dubious housing project in the city of Seongnam, where Lee was mayor for a decade until 2018. Lee has denied legal wrongdoing and accused Yoon's government of pursuing a political vendetta.

Last September, a South Korean court denied an arrest warrant for Lee over the allegations, but Lee faces a continuing investigation by prosecutors. The court hearing was arranged after the opposition-controlled parliament voted to lift Lee's immunity to arrest, a move that reflected growing divisions within his Democratic Party over his legal troubles.

Lee, who also served as governor of Gyeonggi province, which surrounds Seoul, is known for his outspoken style. His supporters see him as an anti-elitist hero who could reform establishment politics, eradicate corruption and solve growing economic inequality. Critics view him as a dangerous populist who relies on stoking divisions and demonizing his conservative opponents.

Violence against high-profile figures has sometimes occurred in South Korea in recent years.

In March 2022, Song Young-gil, then the leader of the Democratic Party, was assaulted by a man wielding a hammer during a rally for Lee ahead of the presidential vote. Song was treated for stitches but avoided serious injury.

In 2015, then-U.S. Ambassador to South Korea Mark Lippert was slashed in the face and arm by an anti-American activist. The assault required 80 stitches to close the cut on Lippert's face.

Plane catches fire at Japan's Haneda airport after collision



PHOTO: AP

A Japan Airlines plane is on fire on the runway of Tokyo's Haneda airport on Tuesday, Jan. 2, 2024.

AP
Tokyo, Jan. 2

A passenger plane burst into flames on the runway of Tokyo's Haneda airport on Tuesday, with news reports saying it hit another aircraft after landing.

NHK TV reported that all occupants of Japan Airlines flight JAL-516, believed to total 379 people, got out safely before the plane was entirely engulfed in flames. The Japanese coast guard, which operated the other plane, said its pilot had escaped but five crewmembers are missing.

Local TV video showed a large eruption of fire and smoke from the side of the Japan Airlines plane as it taxied on a runway. The area around the wing then caught fire. Footage an hour later showed the plane fully on fire.

NHK TV said the plane was an Airbus A-350 that had flown from Shin Chitose airport, near the city of Sapporo, to Haneda.

Coast Guard spokesperson Yoshinori Yanagishima confirmed the collision between the passenger plane and its flight MA-722, a Bombardier Dash-8.

Haneda is one of the busiest airports in Japan, and many people travel over the New Year holidays.

PRISM

Police suspect man was attacked by lion

Kenya: Police in Kenya on Monday recovered the body of a man believed to have been attacked by a lion while he was riding a motorcycle near a national reserve in the south of the country.

Police were notified by community members of an abandoned motorcycle along a road near the Marere forested area near the Shimba Hills National Reserve.

Officers saw lion footprints that led from the motorcycle to a thicket where they found the remains of an unknown dead man, according to a police report.

The lion population was declining in Kenya just over a decade ago, primarily due to human-wildlife conflict. The government listed lions as endangered, with an estimated population of 2,000 in 2010. A more recent survey put the number at 2,489.

Passenger hides bullets in baby diaper

New York: It was a loaded diaper, but not like you would think.

Security officers found 17 bullets concealed inside a disposable baby diaper Wednesday at New York's LaGuardia Airport, the Transportation Security Administration said.

Officers pulled the otherwise clean diaper from a passenger's carry-on bag after it triggered an alarm in an X-ray machine at an airport security checkpoint, the TSA said.

According to the agency, the passenger initially claimed he didn't know how the bullet-filled diaper ended up in his bag. Later he suggested his girlfriend put it there, the agency said.

(Agencies)

Nobel laureate Yunus convicted of violating labour law

AFP
Dhaka, Jan. 2

Nobel peace laureate Muhammad Yunus was convicted on Monday of violating Bangladesh's labour laws in a case decried by his supporters as politically motivated.

Yunus, 83, is credited with lifting millions out of poverty with his pioneering microfinance bank but has earned the enmity of longtime Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, who has accused him of "sucking blood" from the poor.

Hasina has made several scathing verbal attacks against the internationally respected 2006 Nobel Peace Prize winner, who was once seen as a political rival.

Yunus and three colleagues from Grameen Telecom, one of the firms he founded, were accused of violating labour laws when they failed to create a workers' welfare fund in the company.

A labour court in the capital Dhaka convicted and sentenced them to "six months' simple imprisonment", lead prosecutor Khurshid Alam Khan told AFP, adding that all four were immediately granted bail pending appeals.

All four deny the charges. Dozens of people staged a small rally in support of Yunus outside the court.

"I have been punished for a crime that I haven't committed," Yunus told reporters after the hearing.

"If you want to call it justice, you can."

Yunus is facing more than 100 other charges over labour law violations and alleged graft.

He told reporters after one of the hearings last month that he had not profited from any of the more than 50 social business firms he had set up in Bangladesh.



PHOTO: AFP

Nobel Peace Prize winner Muhammad Yunus was sentenced on Jaunary 1, 2024, to six months in jail for violating Bangladesh's labour laws.

"They were not for my personal benefit," Yunus said at the time.

Another of his lawyers, Khaja Tanvir, told AFP that the case was "meritless, false and ill-motivated".

"The sole aim of the case is to harass and humiliate him in front of the world," Tanvir said.

Irene Khan, a former Amnesty chief now working as a UN special rapporteur who was present at Monday's verdict, told AFP the conviction was "a travesty of justice".

"A social activist and Nobel laureate who brought honour and pride to the country is being persecuted on frivolous grounds," she said.

In August, 160 global figures, including former US president Barack Obama and ex-UN secretary-general Ban Ki-moon, published a joint letter denouncing "continuous judicial harassment" of Yunus.

The signatories, including more than 100 of his fellow Nobel laureates, said they feared for "his safety and freedom".

Critics accuse Bangladeshi courts of rubber-stamping decisions made by Hasina's government, which is all but certain to win another term in power next week at elections boycotted by the opposition.

Her administration has been increasingly firm in its crackdown on political dissent, and Yunus's popularity among the Bangladeshi public has for years earmarked him as a potential rival.

Amnesty International accused the government of "weaponizing labour laws" when Yunus went to trial in September and called for an immediate end to his "harassment".

Criminal proceedings against Yunus were "a form of political retaliation for his work and dissent", it said.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1815 – Austria, the United Kingdom, and France form a secret defensive alliance against Prussia and Russia.
1861 – American Civil War: Delaware votes not to secede from the United States.
1870 – Construction work begins on the Brooklyn Bridge in New York, United States.
1911 – A magnitude 7.7 earthquake destroys the city of Almaty in Russian Turkestan.
1911 – A gun battle in the East End of London leaves two dead. It sparked a political row over the involvement of then-Home Secretary Winston Churchill.
1920 – Over 640 are killed after a magnitude 6.4 earthquake strikes the Mexican states Puebla and Veracruz.
1993 – In Moscow, Russia, George H. W. Bush and Boris Yeltsin sign the second Strategic Arms Reduction Treaty (START).

PM MULLING ON RESHUFFLING CABINET: SAPKOTA

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 2

The CPN (Maoist Centre) informed on Tuesday that Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' was planning to reshuffle the Council of Ministers to make the government more effective.

Speaking at a press meeting in the party's central office in Paris Danda held to inform about the 'Conclusion of Special Transformation Campaign, party spokesperson Agni Prasad Sapkota said that the Prime Minister's expressions hinted at his plan to reshuffle the Cabinet.

Sapkota said, "While assessing the expression of the Prime Minister, we can understand that preparations are underway to reshuffle the cabinet if he feels a need to do so."

He said that as the government was a coalition one, a conclusion, however, would be reached only after discussing the issue with the coalition parties.

Sapkota said that the work should move forward even if it means the reshuffling of the ministers. The work of the whole panel of ministers should be made effective. But, a serious and concrete review has not taken place. The Prime Minister has called for the direction about his expression.

Spokesperson Sapkota said that the decision about the Cabinet reshuffle will be made only after a thorough discussion.

DADELDHURA HOSPITAL WITHOUT RADIOLOGIST FOR THREE MONTHS

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dadeldhura, Jan. 2

Dadeldhura Hospital, which is preparing for medical operations, has halted its CT scan service due to a lack of skilled manpower.

Dr. Santosh Gupta, the medical superintendent of the hospital, informed that the CT scan service has been closed for the past three months due to the lack of radiologists.

He said that the Ministry of Health and Population had sent a radiologist who had studied on a scholarship to the Dadeldhura Hospital. He was sent to the hospital on a contract basis 18 months ago.

A student under scholarship needs to do practical courses at hospitals in the remote areas for at least a year. As a result, the radiologist who worked in the Dadeldhura Hospital for one and half a years got transferred to another hospital.

Since the transfer of the radiologist, patients from seven hilly districts of Sudurpaschim Province need to visit Kailali and hospitals in other districts for the service.

Last year, more than 800 patients received the CT-scan services in the Dadeldhura Hospital.

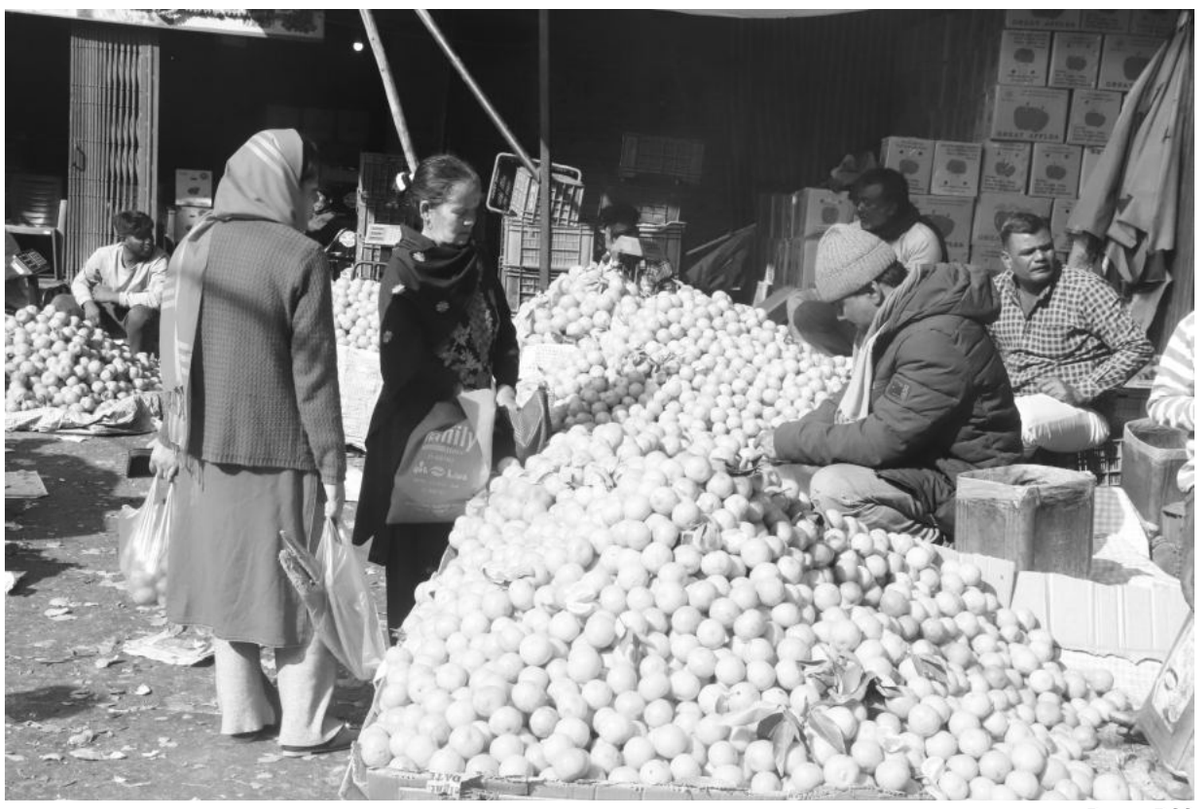


PHOTO: RSS

Women buying oranges at Kalimati Fruit and Vegetable Market in Kathmandu.

Israel is pulling thousands of troops from Gaza

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 2

The Israeli military confirmed Monday that it was pulling thousands of troops out of the Gaza Strip, a step that could clear the way for a new long-term phase of lower-intensity fighting against the Hamas militant group.

The confirmation of the planned troop drawdown came the same day that Israel's Supreme Court struck down a key component of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's contentious judicial overhaul plan. While the plan is not directly connected to the war effort, it was the source of deep divisions inside Israel and had threatened the military's readiness before the Oct. 7 Hamas attack that triggered the ongoing war.

Politicians warned against reigniting those divisions and harming the national unity that has prevailed throughout the Israel-Hamas war.

Netanyahu has vowed to press ahead with the military offensive until Hamas is crushed and the more than 100 hostages still held by the militant group in Gaza are freed.

But Israel has come under growing international pressure to scale back an offensive that has led to the deaths of nearly 22,000 Palestinians. U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken, who has repeatedly urged Israel to do more to protect Palestinian civilians, is expected in the region next week.

In its announcement, the army said that five brigades, or several thousand troops, would be taken out of Gaza in the coming weeks.

Some will return to bases for further training or rest, while many older reservists will go home. The war has taken a toll on the economy by preventing reservists from going to their jobs, running their businesses or returning to university studies.

The army's chief spokesperson, Rear Adm. Daniel Hagari, did not say whether the withdrawal of some troops reflected a new phase of the war.

"The objectives of the war require prolonged fighting, and we are preparing accordingly," he told reporters late Sunday.

But the move is in line with the plans that Israeli leaders have outlined for a low-intensity campaign, expected to last for much of the year, that focuses on remaining Hamas strongholds and "pockets of resistance."

Israel has said it's close to operational control over most of northern Gaza, reducing the need for forces there. Yet fierce fighting has continued in other areas of the Palestinian territory, especially the south, where many of Hamas' forces remain intact and where most of Gaza's 2.3 million people have fled.

Israel has vowed to crush Hamas' military and governing capabilities in the ongoing war, which was sparked by the militant group's Oct. 7 attack on southern Israel in which 1,200 people were killed and 240 others were taken hostage.

Israel responded with an air, ground and sea offensive that has killed more than 21,900 people in Gaza, two-thirds of them women and children, according to the Health Ministry in the Hamas-ruled territory, which does not differentiate between civilians and combatants in its count. The Israeli military says 173 soldiers have died since it launched its ground operation.

Israel also says, without providing evidence, that more than 8,000 militants have been killed. It blames Hamas for the high civilian death toll, saying the militants embed within residential areas, including schools and hospitals.

The war has displaced some 85% of Gaza's population, forcing tens of thousands of people in overcrowded shelters or teeming tent camps in Israeli-designated safe areas that the military has nevertheless bombed. Palestinians are left with a sense that nowhere is safe.

With tensions high across the region, the United States announced Monday that it would send an aircraft carrier strike group home and replace it with an amphibious assault ship and accompanying warships.

In Khan Younis, a city in southern Gaza that Israel says is a key Hamas stronghold, residents reported airstrikes and shelling in the west and center of the city. Combat was also reported in urban refugee camps in central Gaza, where Israel expanded its offensive last week.

An Associated Press reporter saw at least 17 bodies, including those of four children, at a hospital in the central town of Deir al-Balah after a missile struck a house.

"It's our routine: bombings, massacres and martyrs," said Saeed Moustafa, a Palestinian from the Nuseirat camp.

Gaza's Health Ministry said Monday that 156 people had been killed in the past day. The Israeli military said an airstrike killed Adel Mismah, a regional commander of Hamas' elite Nukhba forces, in Deir al-Balah.

In Israel, Kibbutz Be'eri, one of the communities hit by Hamas on Oct. 7, announced Monday that Ilan Weiss, who was thought to have been kidnapped, is now believed to be dead. Weiss' daughter, Noga Weiss, 18; and wife, Shiri Weiss, 53; were held in captivity in Gaza and released on Nov. 25 during a weeklong cease-fire.

Lumbini Provincial Assembly meet sees low attendance

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Ghorahi, Dec. 2

Lumbini Provincial Assembly has completed its first year. Throughout the year, it conducted 35 meetings with 10 in the first session and 25 in the second session.

However, only eight members of the Lumbini Provincial Assembly including Speaker Tularam Gharti Magar attended all of the 35 meetings. Similarly, Khadga Basnet, Indra Kumari Gahatraj, Sita Sharma, Bhagwati Adhikari, Yam Bahadur Nepali Sarki, Bhuwaneshwor Chaudhary and Sushila Badi were present in all meetings.

An attendance report of the secretariat of the Lumbini Provincial Assembly stated that many of the other members of the Lumbini Provincial Assembly were not present in the meeting.

Meanwhile, the Provincial Assembly formulated one law and presented eight bills in the Assembly within a year.

The secretariat informed four of the bills have been endorsed. They include the bill for the formation, operation and conditions of service of the Provincial Civil Service, the bill for the management of the budget allocation and spending from the Province Reserve Fund made by the Provincial Assembly for the service and work for the Fiscal Year 2023/024, the bill for the implementation of the financial proposal of the Provincial Government and the bill to amend Health Institute Establishment, Operation, Renewal and Upgrade Act 2019.

Additionally, the assembly also passed two yearly bills and one amendment bill, said Durlabh Kumar Pun Magar, Secretary of the Lumbini Provincial Assembly.

Earlier, the first Provincial Assembly had made 72 laws and passed 50 basic bills, 10 yearly bills and 12 amendment bills which were implemented as laws.

Turkey detains 33 people suspected of spying for Israel

AP
Ankara Turkey Jan. 2

Turkish authorities have detained 33 people suspected of spying for Israel, Turkey's state-run news agency reported on Tuesday.

Authorities were still searching for 13 others believed to have links to Israel's Mossad security service, the Anadolu Agency reported.

The suspects were detained in raids in Istanbul and seven other provinces for allegedly planning to carry out activities that included "reconnaissance" and "pursuing, assaulting and kidnapping" foreign nationals living in Turkey, the agency reported.

The suspects were allegedly recruited to spy on Palestinians residing in Turkey as well as Israeli activists opposed to their government, Anadolu said. Israeli officials allegedly contacted the suspects via social media, it said.

The report comes weeks after the head of Israel's domestic security agency, Shin Bet, said in an audio recording that his organization is prepared to destroy Hamas "in every place," including in Lebanon, Turkey and Qatar.

Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan warned Israel of "serious consequences" if it pressed ahead with its threat to attack Hamas officials on Turkish soil.

Turkey and Israel had normalized ties in 2022 by reappointing ambassadors following years of tensions. But those ties quickly deteriorated after the Israel-Hamas war, with Ankara becoming one of the strongest critics of Israel's military actions in Gaza.

Israel initially withdrew its diplomats from Turkey over security concerns and later announced it was recalling its diplomats for political reasons, citing "increasingly harsh statements" from Turkish officials. Turkey also pulled out its ambassador from Israel.

Rohingya refugees in Sri Lanka protest planned closure of U.N. office

AP
Colombo, Sri Lanka Jan. 2

A group of Rohingya refugees living in Sri Lanka staged a protest outside the office of the U.N. refugee agency Tuesday, saying they fear losing their living allowance once the agency's office in the island nation closes at the end of this year.

The protesters also want to be resettled in another country because Sri Lanka does not allow them to live there permanently.

About 100 Rohingya refugees live in Sri Lanka, most of them rescued at sea by the navy while they were trying to reach Indonesia after fleeing Myanmar for Bangladesh.

About 740,000 Rohingya were resettled in Bangladesh after fleeing their homes in Myanmar to escape a brutal counterinsurgency campaign by security forces. But the camps in Bangladesh are squalid, with surging gang violence and rampant hunger, leading many to flee again.

Ruki Fernando, a rights activist in Sri Lanka, said the refugees receive basic allowance from the U.N. agency and are provided with limited health care by the Sri Lankan government.

Annapurna region...

and Chait (March-April) to Baisakh (April-May), particularly with improved road access to Mustang and Manang.

The ACAP spreads to 7601 square kilometers of area. The region gained more popularity in the world following its visit by United Nations Secretary General Antonio Gutters last year. At the time, the UN Secretary General said he was memorized by the natural beauty of Nepal and heritages of the Himalaya.

The American news agency CNN identified the Annapurna region as one of world's 23 top destinations to visit in 2023.

Tourist guide Divas Gurung said the Annapurna region is enchanting for tourists due to its natural beauty, biodiversity, Himalayan way of life, culture, and many more.

Indian Minister S....

cussion with former foreign ministers, foreign secretaries and ambassadors to India on Tuesday. Emphasising that Nepal's relationship with India is important, experts suggested increasing Nepal's exports to India, expanding electricity trade, strengthening cross-border infrastructure, emphasising the timely completion of development projects started in the past, and addressing issues such as air routes, informed the FM's Secretariat in a statement on Tuesday.

The MoFA source said that the meeting would deliberate on the energy trade and border issues as well. India is Nepal's largest partner with about two thirds of foreign trade happening with it. Participants of the discussion included former Foreign Minister Dr. Bhesh Bahadur Thapa, former foreign secretaries Madhu Raman Acharya, Arjun Thapa, Durga Bhattarai, Bharat Raj Poudyal and former ambassador to India Durgesh Man Singh.

Meanwhile, FM Saud held a meeting with a joint delegation of Canada-Nepal Chamber of Commerce and Canadian Hindu Chamber of Commerce at his office in Singha Durbar on Tuesday. During the meeting Minister Saud assured them that the government would leave no stone unturned to facilitate foreign investment in Nepal.

Talking about the upcoming Nepal Investment Summit, he urged them to bring in investment to Nepal. Canadian Hindu Chamber of Commerce President Naresh Kumar Chavda said that the Canadian private sector wanted to work in Nepal, especially in the fields of agriculture, food, textiles and hydropower.

Canada-Nepal Chamber of Commerce President Bijaya Paudel and Chavda had led their respective delegation to the meeting.

GOVERNMENT OF NEPAL (GoN)

MASTER GENERAL OF ORDNANCE (PROVISION)

NEPALI ARMY HEADQUARTERS, BHADRAKALI, KATHMANDU, NEPAL

Invitation e-Bids for Electric Cart, Equipment for Workshop, AC, Pallet & Trolley

First Date of Publication: 03 January, 2024

1. The Master General of Ordnance (MGO) (Provision), Nepali Army Headquarters invites electronic bids from eligible bidders for the procurement of the following items required for the Nepali Army under International Competitive Bidding (ICB) procedures specified in Public Procurement Act and Regulations:

S.No.	Contract Identification No:	Description of Item	Quantity	Price of Bid Document NRs	Bid Bond Amount NRs	Bid Validity	Pre-bid Meeting	Last date of Bid submission	Bid Opening
1.	MGO/Electric Cart, Equipment for Workshop, AC, Pallet & Trolley/080/81/27 (DPO)	Electric Cart, Equipment for Workshop, AC 1.5 Ton, Pallet Jack & Department Trolley	Various	3,000.00	4,72,000.00	90 Days	1100 hours NST of 18 January, 2024.	1200 Hours NST of 18 February, 2024.	1300 Hours NST of 18 February, 2024.

2. Eligible Bidders may visit PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp or obtain further information and inspect the bidding documents at the Office of MGO (Provision), Nepali Army Headquarters, Bhadrakali, Kathmandu, Nepal (Tel. +977-1-5979124) during office hours. Bids must be accompanied by bid security, amounting to above mentioned **bid bond amount** (Equivalent amount in bid currency at selling exchange rate published by Nepal Rastra Bank on bid notice publication date).
3. Fee of bidding document must be deposited in Account Name Nepali Army Welfare Fund, Jangi Adda to Account No. 00101010264181 of Nepal Investment Bank Limited.

Mahajatra's first poster unveiled



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 2

The first poster of 'Mahajatra' was unveiled on Tuesday.

The poster featured actors Haribansha Acharya, Bipin Karki, Rabindra Singh Baniya and Rabindra Jha.

In the poster, the three characters known as Phadindra (Bipin), Joyesha (Rabindra Baniya) and Munna (Rabindra Jha) are depicted pushing actor Acharya in a wheelchair with currency notes flying around them.

The poster indicates that actor Acharya has been captivated.

Baniya, the actor and executive producer of the film, informed that the poster revealed the major plot of the movie. Following the success of 'Jatra' and 'Jatrai Jatra', the threequel 'Mahajatra' was produced by ShatkonArts exploring the challenges of pursuing a fulfilling life and seizing unexpected opportunities.

Director Pradip Bhattarai emphasised that the film balances laughter and tears.

The cast includes Barsha Raut, Arjun Jung Shahi, Prakash Ghimire, Rajaram Paudel, Prabin Khatiwada, Divyadev, Suman Karki, Shishir Bangdel, Gaumaya Gurung and Arbin Khadka. The international screening rights have already been acquired by MSM Entertainment.

Produced by Yagyashor Paudel and Max Dipesh Khatri, 'Mahajatra' is set to be released simultaneously in Nepal and worldwide on March 22.

Purushottam Pradhan has directed the Cinematography of the film while Kumar Maharjan served as the fight director in the film.

Three authors honoured

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Lalitpur, Dec. 2



World Nepali Literature Federation Lalitpur branch honoured three authors active in Nepali literature at a literary function organised in Lalitpur recently.

At the fourth literary serial of the branch, senior poet Shailendra Sakar was felicitated with Sahitya Shree Honour. Likewise, Poet Avaya Shrestha was awarded with Lalit Kavya Honour for the contribution in poetry while novelist Bijay Hitan with Srasta Shree Honour for his contribution to the field of eco-literature.

Chairman of Jyoti Literature Academy Maniraj Singh handed over the letter of honour to poet Sakar while Sakar and Singh did the same to Shrestha and Hitan.

At the programme, a poetry competition was also held among students of Pawan Prakriti School of Tikathali, Lalitpur. Poet Sakar gave away the awards and certificates to three winners of the competition. Chairman of the branch Buddhiman Maharjan informed that the competition will be held every month in the series for which the competitors should send their poems by the first week of every month.

Maharjan, Sakar, Singh, Divya Giri, Sudha Mishra, Bijay Hitan, Renu Ghimire, Sangita Thakur, Yamuna Pradhananga, Rajesh Man KC, Ramnath Adhikari, Neera Shrestha, Juman Kiran, Rubina Rana Magar, Harka Kunwar, Bishnu Rai, KB Paudel and Sunita Adhikari recited their poems. Certificates to the new members of the branch were also distributed at the same function.

According to general secretary of the branch Sudha Mishra, the literary serial is being held on the second Saturday of every month in different areas of Lalitpur district.

Jeremy Renner set to head back to work on 'Mayor of Kingstown'

AGENCIES
New York, Jan. 2



Jeremy Renner has revealed a major step in his career after a terrible accident nearly took his life: He's headed back to the set of "Mayor of Kingstown" to film the third season.

Renner was involved in a near-fatal accident on Jan. 1, 2023, after saving his nephew from being hit by a snowplow. The actor was run over by his own Sno-Cat, which weighs at least 14,330 pounds, putting Renner in the hospital with blunt chest trauma and orthopedic injuries.

As Renner continues to recover, he spoke with Andy Cohen and Anderson Cooper during their CNN New Year's Eve special about his physical therapy, as well as his upcoming album.

"We have a lot to celebrate this year," Renner said. "I'm so blessed that I had so many things to live for. I have a giant family, a 10-year-old daughter. I would have disappointed and messed up a lot of people's lives if I passed. There's a lot for me to fight for. Recovery is a one-way road in my mind. I still work hard every day."

Renner was also asked about going back to work on the third season of "Kingstown." "It's been a wonderfully busy year," he said. "I think I'm ready and I think I'm strong enough. I literally go back in a week."

The "Hawkeye" actor has been active in keeping his fans updated on his recovery. He made a concerted effort to be well enough to walk the red carpet with the use of a cane at the world premiere of his Disney+ series "Rennervations" last April.

In an interview with ABC News' Diane Sawyer last April, Renner went into detail about how exactly the incident occurred and explained that he's fine allowing a stunt double perform more physical duties on set after his injuries.

"Last night, I didn't sleep for shit knowing I was going to have to talk about it today. I have no regrets. I'd do it again," he said in the interview, adding: "I refuse to have that be a trauma and be a negative experience. That is a man that I'm proud of because I wouldn't let that happen to my nephew. I shift the narrative of being victimized, or making a mistake, or anything else. I refuse to be fucking haunted by that memory that way."



PHOTO: RAJAN RAWAT

Donned in traditional attire and jewellries, women of Halji village located beyond the Himalayas in Namkha Rural Municipality-6 pose for a photograph after performing puja on the last day of Lhosar on Tuesday.

John Abraham acquires a lavish bungalow in Mumbai for INR 750 million

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Jan. 2

Bollywood actor and producer John Abraham has acquired a luxurious property in the upscale Khar area of the city for over INR 750 million.

The 51-year-old actor-producer, known for his roles in the film industry and as an astute investor in realty projects and companies, resides in a sea-facing penthouse at Hiten Apartments on Shirley Rajan Road in Bandra West.

The property, a 13,138 sqft bungalow in Khar, was purchased for approximately INR 750 million and has the potential for redevelopment. According to the broker, Abraham paid INR 708.3 million to the seller and INR 42.5 million in stamp duties to the BMC on December 27.

The 51-year-old star is known for being a keen property investor, involved in various companies and with numerous projects in the pipeline, including The Diplomat, Tehran, Tariq, and Vedaa, as per film industry sources.

Abraham is reported to have invested in multiple companies spanning online, food and beverages, community, fitness, lifestyle, and real estate.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: To-do list? More like "already done" list! While you may be a little more irritable than usual, Aries, you also have the verve to get tons done -- as long as you can channel this energy into your desired goals.

Taurus: Now may not be the time to take that risk with your hair. You might have been considering a bold style change, dramatic wardrobe addition, or another exciting alteration to your looks, but by the time everything is said and done.

Gemini: Risky behavior might land you into hot water with someone close to you. Since you likely enjoy shaking things up now and then, this might sound like it can't be too bad.

Cancer: The enemy of your enemy might not be your friend. You're possibly befriending someone who is a bit negative, but the two of you still bond over disliking the same people and things.

Leo: A risk you take could wound another person at the moment. You'll potentially encounter a chance to have tons of fun -- but this activity may prevent you from fulfilling a commitment that you've already made to someone else.

Virgo: Your desire to be nurturing may outweigh your aspiration to stay firm. Lines can be crossed today, especially if someone who already has tried to push your boundaries is struggling.

Libra: Your friends or peers could be encouraging you to do something that you're not really interested in. This activity may be something that you're not comfortable or experienced with, and while they want you to join in with them.

Scorpio: Your intuition might not line up with what you can see at this time. Even if everything appears completely wonderful and peaceful on the surface, you may sense that something is off.

Sagittarius: Today's distracting calls might be coming from inside the house! You're possibly bursting with impulsive energy, craving the risk of running wherever your mind takes you!

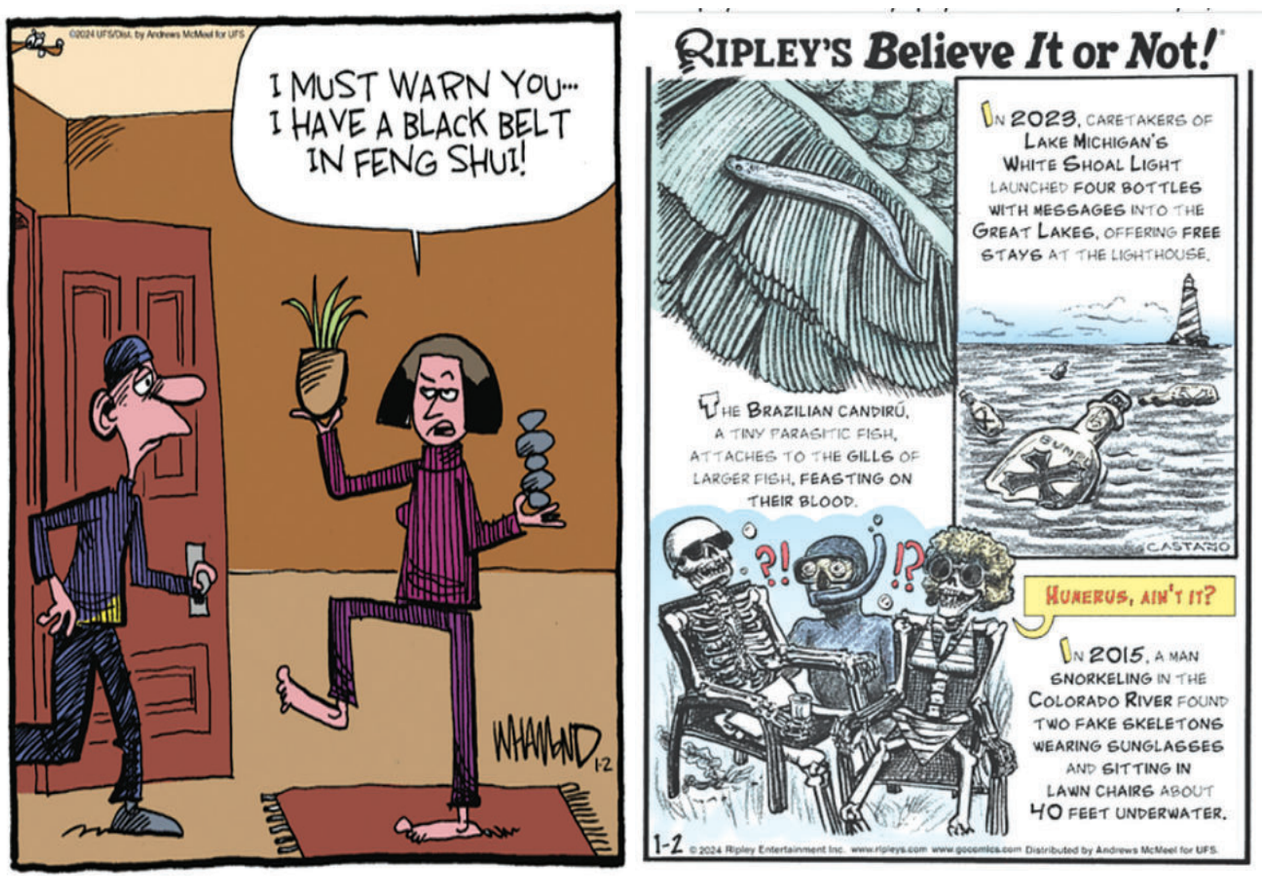
Capricorn: You may be losing steam. Perhaps when you started on a project, you had a lot of energy and inspiration for it, but now that you're in the middle of the process and have experienced some trial and error, you might be ready to give up.

Aquarius: Past lessons can be relevant in the present. Your sign is known for efforts to make what you do as original as possible, but too much deviation may net you practically unrecognizable results.

Pisces: You might have a good idea that you're keeping under wraps. While it's wise to avoid bragging about your chicks before they hatch, this notion could be better served by being shared with others.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Salah sends Liverpool three points clear atop

AFP
Liverpool, Jan. 2



Mohamed Salah scored twice as Liverpool stretched Newcastle's miserable run with a 4-2 victory at Anfield to open up a three-point lead at the top of the Premier League on Monday.

Jurgen Klopp's team should have run out even more convincing winners as Martin Dubravka saved Salah's first-half penalty among 10 stops.

But Salah made amends from the spot after he, Curtis Jones and Cody Gakpo had netted in the second half to inflict a seventh defeat in eight games on Newcastle.

Liverpool head into the Premier League's winter break five points clear of title rivals Manchester City and Arsenal, with Aston Villa posing an unexpected challenge in second place.

"A special game, special night," said Klopp. "It was a sensational game from my team. We started extremely lively. Everyone saw Dubravka or we ourselves made sure the score didn't get too clear.

"Super game. I loved so many aspects of the game bar the goals we conceded."

Newcastle, by contrast, remain down in ninth and 11 points off the top four as the spotlight grows on Eddie Howe.

The Magpies have the second worst away record in the Premier League this season with just five points from 10 games.

Howe's men were fortunate not to be blown away by an embarrassing scoreline in stormy conditions at Anfield as Liverpool registered the highest expected goals ever in a Premier League game of 7.53. "We're battling to get our best levels back. The effort and determination was there. As long as we continue to see that we'll be fine," said Howe.

"We're missing a lot of players and we've had a lot of tough fixtures in a congested December."

Dubravka denies Darwin

Dubravka has struggled to deputise for the sidelined Nick Pope as Newcastle's form has slumped in recent weeks while battling an injury crisis.

But the Slovakian was in top form as he denied Darwin Nunez on a handful of ocassions.

Luis Diaz did have the ball in the net midway through the first half, but the goal was ruled out for offside against Nunez.

Diaz was then upended in the box by Sven Botman. But Dubravka bailed out the Dutch defender by denying Salah his 150th Premier League goal for Liverpool from the spot.

The Egyptian, who was playing in his final game before heading out to the African Cup of Nations, has now missed four of his last 10 spot-kicks for the Reds.

"I thought 'are you going to be leave for the national team with that performance?'" said Salah of his first-half display.

"I just had to really focus, step up and make the difference and managed to do so."

Finally Liverpool's pressure told early in the second period as for once Nunez showed a cool head to pick out Salah for a tap in.

But completely against the run of play, Newcastle equalised just five minutes after falling behind.

Alexander Isak timed his run to perfection to latch onto Anthony Gordon's through ball and the Swedish striker slotted confidently past the advancing Alisson Becker.

That shock did not change the course of the game as the one-way traffic towards the Newcastle goal continued.

Nunez's night ended in frustration as another golden chance came and went with his final touch as he headed wide.

Klopp sent on Diogo Jota and Gakpo and they delivered what Nunez could not in front of goal.

Jota teed up Jones for a tap in before Gakpo's scuffed finish from Salah's cross wrong-footed Dubravka.

Botman's header briefly brought Newcastle back within one goal.

But any hope of a remarkable fightback was extinguished in controversial fashion as Jota won a second penalty despite a delayed reaction to contact from Dubravka.

Klopp could not watch on the touchline, but this time his talisman did not disappoint to ensure the start to 2024 was a very happy new year for Liverpool.

Elgar bids to bow out on winning note

AFP
Cape Town, Jan. 2



Dean Elgar will bid to bring the curtain down on his Test career by skippering South Africa to victory in the second and final Test against an India side who are likely to make at least two changes.

The tourists hopes of achieving their first ever series success in South Africa were comprehensively dashed as they lost the first Test by an innings-and-32 runs last Thursday.

South Africa will be revved up to give Elgar a victorious farewell.

The 36-year-old will captain the side -- standing in for the injured Temba Bavuma -- and is in fine fettle having scored a majestic 185 in the first Test.

India look set to revamp their bowling attack.

Left-arm spin bowling all-rounder Ravindra Jadeja is expected to return in place of off-spinner Ravichandran Ashwin.

Jadeja suffered a back spasm before play on the first day of the first Test.

Jadeja will add depth to India's batting, which crumbled in Centurion, as well as being a capable bowler.

India are also likely to make at least one more change to their bowling line-up.

Jasprit Bumrah and Mohammed Siraj maintained reasonable control in Centurion but lacked support from all-rounder Shardul Thakur and newcomer Prasidh Krishna.

At least one of Mukesh Kumar and Avesh Khan is in line to play at Newlands.

Avesh was added to the squad after impressive performances in India's one-day series win which preceded the Test matches, which he followed with a five-wicket haul for India A against South Africa A last week.

With the exception of Virat Kohli and KL Rahul, India's batsmen looked ill-equipped to deal with South Africa's all-pace attack.

Captain Rohit Sharma continued to struggle in South African conditions, being dismissed twice by Kagiso Rabada for five and nought.

In five Tests in South Africa, Sharma has only scored 128 runs at an average of 12.80, compared to an overall Test average of 45.45.

Young batsmen Yashasvi Jaiswal, Shubman Gill and Shreyas Iyer all looked vulnerable against the fast bowlers.

Conditions at Newlands are unlikely to favour fast bowling as much as they did at Centurion but bowlers can still expect some assistance.

The pitch had a covering of green grass on Monday although the surface would be mowed before the match.

Aside from Bavuma the hosts will also be without fast bowler Gerald Coetzee who suffered a pelvic injury during South Africa's win, achieved in three days.

South Africa will want to accommodate left-arm spin bowler Keshav Maharaj and will have to decide whether to pick a specialist batsman in Bavuma's place.

Either Zubayr Hamza or Tristan Stubbs could come in as a batsman or they may opt for five bowlers with Marco Jansen filling the all-rounder position, batting at number seven.

Lungi Ngidi, who was judged not to have fully recovered from an ankle injury, is expected to be fit for selection.

WUMA KUNG FU JUDGE SANJEET FETED



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 17

Sanjeet Kumar Rai, an international judge of WUMA Kung Fu, has been honoured in Texas, USA. The Kirat Rai Society, America, feted Sanjeet during the Paruhang Evening-2 event for his contribution towards enhancing the reputation of Nepal and the Kirat Rai community through sports.

Dennis Webb, the Deputy Mayor of the City of Irving, Khagendra Rai, the President of Kirat Rai Society, and Dilip Rai, the President of Kirat Rai Society, Texas Chapter, felicititated Sanjeet during the function.

Veteran WUMA Kung Fu player Sanjeet is a two-time national champion and a gold medalist at the WMAC WUMA World Championship held in Slovenia. He has also served as a judge in various national and international competitions. Currently, Sanjeet is in the US to compete in the Battle of the Dragon Championship and judge the tournament. He is also the senior vice president of the Nepal WUMA Kung Fu Association.

Expressing his gratitude, Sanjeet thanked the Kirat Rai Society for the honour and stated that it had inspired him to be more active in sports.

Nadal returns with win

AFP
Brisbane, Jan. 2



Rafael Nadal won his first match back from a year-long injury layoff when he defeated former US Open champion Dominic Thiem at the Brisbane International on Tuesday, calling it an "emotional and important day".

The 22-time Grand Slam winner looked in superb touch with a clinical 7-5, 6-1 victory over the Austrian in front of a full house at Pat Rafter Arena.

The 37-year-old Spaniard has not played singles since a second-round loss at the Australian Open last year, undergoing two rounds of hip surgery.

"Today, honestly, is an emotional and important day for me after probably one of the toughest years of my tennis career, without a doubt," he said.

"To have the chance to come back after a year and play in front of an amazing crowd, and play I think at a very positive level for the first day is something that makes us feel proud.

"For myself, all the team and my family who have been there every single day during the last year." The long layoff raised fears that his career could be over, but Nadal said this week he was always determined to make it back for the 2024 season.

He conceded before the match there was "a high percentage" that it would be his last season, but left the door open to play on should his body hold up.

"I missed being healthy, I missed feeling competitive and to play in front of full crowds like this," he added courtside after beating Thiem in 89 minutes.

Nadal spent time at his academy in Kuwait to prepare for the Australian summer and trained there with fast-rising French teen Arthur Fils.

PAKISTAN LEAVE OUT SHAHEEN

AFP
Sydney, Jan. 2

Australia opted Tuesday against playing a second spinner in the final Test against Pakistan at the Sydney Cricket Ground, naming an unchanged line-up for David Warner's farewell match.

Skipper Pat Cummins confirmed Australia's fast-bowling trio had all recovered well from the second Test in Melbourne four days ago after clinching the three-match series with a tense 79-run win.

Pakistan have made two changes. There is a Test debut for Saim Ayub, who will open the innings replacing Imam-Ul-Haq while senior fast bowler Shaheen Shah Afridi has been left out for off-spinner Sajid Khan.

"You always have to look at the bigger picture after a game like the MCG. We've learned the lessons, at least we've put ourselves in those positions from where we could compete in or dominate games," Pakistan captain Shan Masood said Tuesday. "It's now about not repeating mistakes, and if we can put in similar efforts to the one in Melbourne, we'll be winning a lot of Tests."

Rooney hit hard by 'setback' after Birmingham City sacking

AFP
London, Jan. 2

Wayne Rooney said it would "take some time to get over this setback" after he was sacked as manager of Championship side Birmingham City on Tuesday following a disastrous spell in charge.

The 38-year-old former Manchester United and England star was appointed in October but oversaw just two wins in 15 matches with Monday's 3-0 thumping by Leeds, their ninth defeat under him, proving the final straw.

Birmingham -- who have NFL legend Tom Brady as a minority shareholder -- are embroiled in a battle against relegation, slumping to 20th from sixth since Rooney took over.

"Despite their best efforts, results have not met the expectations that were made clear at the outset," read a statement from the club.

"Therefore, the board feels that a change in management is in the best interests of the football club." Rooney replaced John Eustace, who was sacked just after he had guided Birmingham to two successive wins which propelled them into the play-off places.

"Football is a results business -- and I recognise they have not been at the level I wanted them to be," said Rooney.

"However, time is the most precious commodity a manager requires and I do not believe 13 weeks was sufficient to oversee the changes that were needed.

"Personally, it will take me some time to get over this setback.

"I have been involved in professional football, as either a player or manager, since I was 16.

"Now, I plan to take some time with my family as I prepare for the next opportunity in my journey as a manager." Rooney's chequered managerial career is in stark contrast to his stellar playing days.

He was credited with doing a decent job at Derby in tricky circumstances. He saved them from relegation in 2021 -- by a point -- after four months in the role.

However, his first full season in charge (2021/22) the club was penalised 21 points for being in administration and English Football League breaches, while they were barred from dealing in the transfer market. Although they made a decent fight of it they were rel- egated to the third tier League One and Rooney left in June 2022 with the club still in administration.

His next destination was the MLS club DC United in July 2022.

They finished bottom of the Eastern Conference, but they improved in the 2023 campaign, finishing 12th.

His overall record, though, as a manager is unimpressive with just 41 victories and 73 defeats in 152 matches.



WEATHER

Wednesday

Sunrise at 6:55 am, Sunset at 5:21 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Wednesday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Possibility of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Tuesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.2	3.5	0.0
Dipayal	24.2	4.9	0.0
Dhangadi	21.4	6.0	0.0
Birendranagar	22.5	4.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	21.0	6.5	0.0
Jumla	16.5	-5.5	0.0
Ghorahi	21.5	7.0	0.0
Pokhara	20.7	8.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	18.8	6.8	0.0
Simara	17.3	6.0	0.0
Kathmandu	17.7	5.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.3	7.2	0.0
Taplejung	15.8	4.8	0.0
Dhankuta	22.1	8.3	0.0
Biratnagar	20.3	10.4	0.0
Jomsom	13.0	-4.5	0.0*
Dharan	23.4	8.5	0.0*
Lumle	15.6	6.3	0.0*
Janakpur	21.5	9.4	0.0*
Jiri	14.7	0.3	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 3, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 133.02	Rs. 133.62
Euro	1	Rs. 146.03	Rs. 146.69
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.54	Rs. 169.30
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 156.73	Rs. 157.44
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.44	Rs. 90.85
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.28	Rs. 100.73
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.40	Rs.100.86
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.38	Rs. 9.42
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.63	Rs. 18.72
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.47	Rs. 35.63
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.50	Rs. 36.66
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.89	Rs. 3.90
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.22	Rs. 36.38
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.90	Rs. 29.03
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.14	Rs. 10.19
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.14	Rs. 13.20
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.59	Rs. 19.68
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.02	Rs. 17.10
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.61	Rs. 434.56
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.85	Rs. 354.44

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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